



Building Hope
42 Years
of
Habitat for Humanity
India

A world where everyone has a
decent place to live.

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Preface

Mrs. Sheila Kripalani

Chairperson – Board of Trustees,
Habitat for Humanity India

My journey with Habitat for Humanity India has been inspiring, fulfilling and one of learning.

It has been an honour for me to be a part of Habitat’s remarkable legacy spanning over four decades. I have witnessed how safe and secure homes transform lives of families and communities. Every home built lays a foundation of hope, opportunity and resilience, especially for women who often bear the weight of the household, added to community and social pressures. I have been fortunate to see this transformation during my interactions with rural communities across India.

The 20-year journey of the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee, chaired by Mrs. Rajashree Birla has exemplified visionary leadership, collaboration and dedication. My sincere appreciation and gratitude for her leadership and the advisory board for their care and support for the less privileged citizens of our country despite their busy schedules.

I am humbled to have been part of Habitat India’s journey alongside passionate and respected members of the Board of Trustees, philanthropic partners and countless volunteers who have built homes, communities and hope.

This coffee table book is a celebration of hope, resilience and the transformative power of secure housing. Every page reflects the many lives that have been touched, communities transformed and many dreams realised through Habitat India’s unwavering commitment of ensuring that everyone has a decent place to live.

I hope that as you turn these pages, you will feel the same sense of purpose, hope and inspiration that drives Habitat India every day.

Looking ahead, my commitment to Habitat remains unwavering. We need to continue building homes that empower families and strengthen communities. Together we can fulfil the dreams of safe, thriving neighbourhoods into a reality for every family in India.



Safe and secure
homes transform
lives of families
and communities.



Foreword

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We have walked side by side with Habitat for Humanity for now over 25 years, spreading the message that decent housing is at the core of living a decent life.

Mrs. Rajashree Birla

Aditya Birla Group
Chairperson – IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee,
Habitat for Humanity India

First of all, let me call out the leadership team for making Habitat for Humanity a major chapter in the history book of human endeavours in the face of daunting challenges to have a roof over their head. Facing moments of tribulations and triumphs for over these four decades and with their boundless energy, relentless efforts and unflinching commitment, doing everything to fulfil our collective noble mission of building a home for the unfortunately underprivileged.

We have walked side by side with Habitat for now over 25 years, spreading the message that decent housing is at the core of living a decent life, which in turn root strong communities. It is this belief that spawned the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee, a strong advocate and a great pull factor for business leaders to lend their voice, vision and pocket share for the poor.

Much must be said of this collaborative effort. The outcome is excellent along with the optics. In India Habitat has been able to serve over 7.7 million people through housing, disaster response, water sanitation and hygiene (WASH) directly and through its network organisations. For these people, there has been a new dawn of hope and fulfilment.

I am also delighted with our visionary Prime Minister's clarion call of housing for all in the near future. My vision for the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee is to contribute to the Government of India's mission. Have a decent living space for all, which at the end of the day they can call a home. A happy place to be in.



Introduction

Mr. Anand Kumar Bolimera

National Director
Habitat for Humanity India

A home is more than brick and mortar — it is a sanctuary, a promise of dignity, safety and belonging. It is where hope takes root and futures begin to unfold. For over four decades, Habitat for Humanity India has been part of countless such journeys laying the foundation not just for homes, but for dreams, resilience and new beginnings.

Every home we help build tells a story of courage in the face of hardship, of a mother's unwavering resolve, of a child's laughter returning to a place once touched by uncertainty. These walls do more than shelter families; they nurture dignity, health, education and the safety of women and children. They hold the quiet yet powerful truth that housing is not a privilege — it is a basic human right and the cornerstone of a life lived in security and hope.

Yet, the housing challenge before us remains immense. Families across our nation continue to live without adequate shelter and this affects every aspect of their lives. To address this, it is vital that housing be recognised and prioritised under Schedule VII of the Companies Act, which defines activities under Corporate Social Responsibility, in alignment with the Government of India's flagship programmes such as the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (Prime Minister's Housing Scheme) to ensure inclusive and holistic development. When we integrate housing into the nation's development agenda, we don't just build structures we build pathways for a sustainable future.

Our journey has been made possible by the compassion and commitment of our partners donors, volunteers, corporates, governments and communities who walk this path with us. Together, we have demonstrated what collective action can achieve when driven by empathy and purpose.

As we celebrate over 42 years of impact and 20 years of the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee, I invite you to continue this journey with us because none of us can live in dignity until everyone does.

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This coffee table book is a tribute to the hands that build, the hearts that give and the families who inspire us every day.



The Habitat *Journey*



Building opportunities amidst challenges

India continues to
play a pivotal role
in Habitat's global
vision of a world
where everyone
has a decent
place to live.

Mr. Jonathan Reckford

Chief Executive Officer
Habitat for Humanity International

For more than four decades, Habitat for Humanity India has been building homes, communities and hope - touching countless lives across the country. This 42-year journey is filled with stories of lives transformed through safe, stable and affordable shelter.

A defining moment in that journey and in my own came in 2006, when I joined President and Mrs. Carter for the Jimmy and Rosalynn Carter Work Project in Lonavala. It brought global attention to the cause of housing and Habitat's work in India and catalysed transformative change on the ground.

I am often reminded of Habitat's impact through the words of two homeowners who told me that although they came from different faiths, their Habitat homes had made them more than neighbours, they had become brothers. That simple yet profound expression captures the heart of our mission. We do not just build houses; we build dignity, unity and belonging.

This year, we also celebrate 20 years of the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee, a visionary leadership collective that has opened doors to partnerships and strengthened Habitat India's work. On my visit to India last year, one of the highlights was meeting with members of the committee. I was deeply encouraged to see the passion, wisdom and commitment they continue to bring to Habitat's mission.

India continues to play a pivotal role in Habitat's global vision of a world where everyone has a decent place to live. The challenges before us are immense, but the opportunities are just as great. By working together, we can build homes that are not only safe and affordable, but also resilient and sustainable.

As we celebrate this milestone, I want to thank all of you who have walked alongside Habitat India on this journey. Your leadership inspires hope. Your commitment changes lives. And together, we will continue to build a future where every family is happier, healthier and more secure through decent housing.



Foundation of collaboration

Mr. Patrick Canagasingham

Chief Operating Officer,
Habitat for Humanity International

For more than four decades, Habitat for Humanity India has shown what is possible when conviction meets compassion. What began as a modest effort to build safe homes has grown into a nationwide movement that affirms a simple truth that every person deserves the dignity and opportunity that a decent home provides.

India's story with Habitat is deeply inspiring. From Khammam in 1983 to communities across the country today, families have shown extraordinary resilience and hope. Each home stands as a symbol of partnership between people who dare to dream and those who believe that transformation begins with a single act of faith and generosity.

The IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee has embodied that belief for twenty years. Their leadership and advocacy have not only expanded Habitat's reach but also redefined what partnership looks like when business leaders, philanthropists and citizens join hands to advance shared humanity.

As we celebrate this remarkable journey, we are also reminded that our mission remains unfinished. The housing challenge is vast, but so too is the collective will of people determined to create change. May this book serve as a celebration of lives transformed and an invitation to every leader to build boldly, act compassionately and ensure that every Indian family has a safe place to call home.

Each home stands
as a symbol of
partnership between
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who believe that
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with a single act of
faith and generosity.



Sustainable impact through affordable housing

Ms. Elizabeth Satow

Area Vice President, Asia-Pacific
Habitat for Humanity International

In 2024, I had the privilege of visiting India and witnessing the remarkable work of Habitat for Humanity India. What I saw went far beyond bricks and mortar. Habitat India is not just building homes, it is building futures. Through integrated, community-driven programs, it is transforming lives and creating sustainable impact for families across the country.

India's housing challenge is immense, but so is the opportunity. As a trusted partner embedded in some of the country's most vulnerable communities, Habitat for Humanity India draws on deep grassroots relationships, technical expertise and policy advocacy to unite public, private and civil society actors around a shared mission.

As one of the few NGOs in India dedicated exclusively to affordable housing, Habitat India fills a critical gap pioneering inclusive solutions for those who are often left behind. From housing finance to post-disaster reconstruction, from upgrading informal settlements to building climate-resilient shelter, its work is reshaping what's possible for millions. At Habitat, we know that decent housing is not just a roof, it is the foundation for health, education, safety and dignity.

This transformative work would not be possible without the ongoing commitment of Habitat for Humanity India's supporters, especially the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee, whom we congratulate on their 20th anniversary. As we celebrate this milestone, we also look ahead with hope and ambition. The next 20 years hold even greater potential to scale impact, deepen partnerships and reach those still waiting for a decent place to live. With your continued generosity, Habitat for Humanity India can expand its reach, innovate solutions and contribute meaningfully to India's housing commitments.

As Habitat for Humanity India marks its 42nd anniversary, its unwavering vision continues to inspire volunteers, donors and communities across the country. My deepest congratulations to the entire Habitat for Humanity India team for their commitment, their courage and their belief in a world where everyone has a decent place to live.

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At Habitat, we know that decent housing is not just a roof—it is the foundation for health, education, safety and dignity.



Experiencing the joy of giving

Mr. Harlan Stone

Chairperson - Aisa Pacific Development Council,
Habitat for Humanity International
President and CEO, HMTX Industries, USA and Hong Kong

Housing is the beginning of building a community. Every family that lives together needs a place to call home that is safe, resilient, inspiring and affordable. This is true in India just as it's true in every other country in the world. We are Habitat for Humanity, which means building shelter for people. People are at the center of our efforts and every person has the human right to housing. It is not only a matter of safety, sustainability and economic prosperity; it is also a source of dignity.

My time as a member of the Asia Pacific Development Council (APDC) started over ten years ago. I was introduced to this part of the Habitat eco-system by the APDC founder, Ron Terwilliger. Little did I know what a tremendous impact this would have on my life. During the past decade, I have learned so much and become deeply involved in fostering change throughout the region. I have seen the impact of our work and I have made so many lifelong friends. But above it all, I have experienced the emotion of meeting the homeowners and community members who have been impacted by the efforts of Habitat for Humanity.

We are very fortunate to have the opportunity to be giving of ourselves: our time, our sweat and hard work, our heart and our resources to bring joy to others. This is the mission of Habitat for Humanity and it is one of the most satisfying things that anyone can experience. Together, we make the world a more fair and loving place. We have the joy of giving and this is one of the greatest joys there is.

Here in India, the impact of the leadership of Habitat India team has been incredible. The hearts of the volunteer leaders are full of kindness and compassion. I feel so lucky to call them my friends and mentors. Together, we can do so much and when we do it with love, the results are bringing dignity forward. Yet there is much more we need to do and expanding that circle of friends is critical to our mission. Let's open our arms and welcome new people to our community of givers. Please join us as we do this work. It will fill your heart with happiness.

.....
Together, we make the world a more fair and loving place. We have the joy of giving, and this is one of the greatest joys there is.



Resonance of the Infinite

Digital Artist :

Samiksha Somani

Softwares Used :

Adobe Photoshop, Adobe Illustrator and Procreate

Artistic Technique :

A digital reinterpretation blending hand-drawn linear patterns and symbolic geometry into a contemporary visual language.

Design Principles :

Symmetry, Repetition and Rhythmic balance

Medium :

Digital illustration using vector techniques

Art & Craft styles :

Warli Art and Chittara art

Curator :

Dr. Rikimi Madhukaillya

Conceptualiser & Artistic Director :

Akhil Vadehra

Craft Researchers :

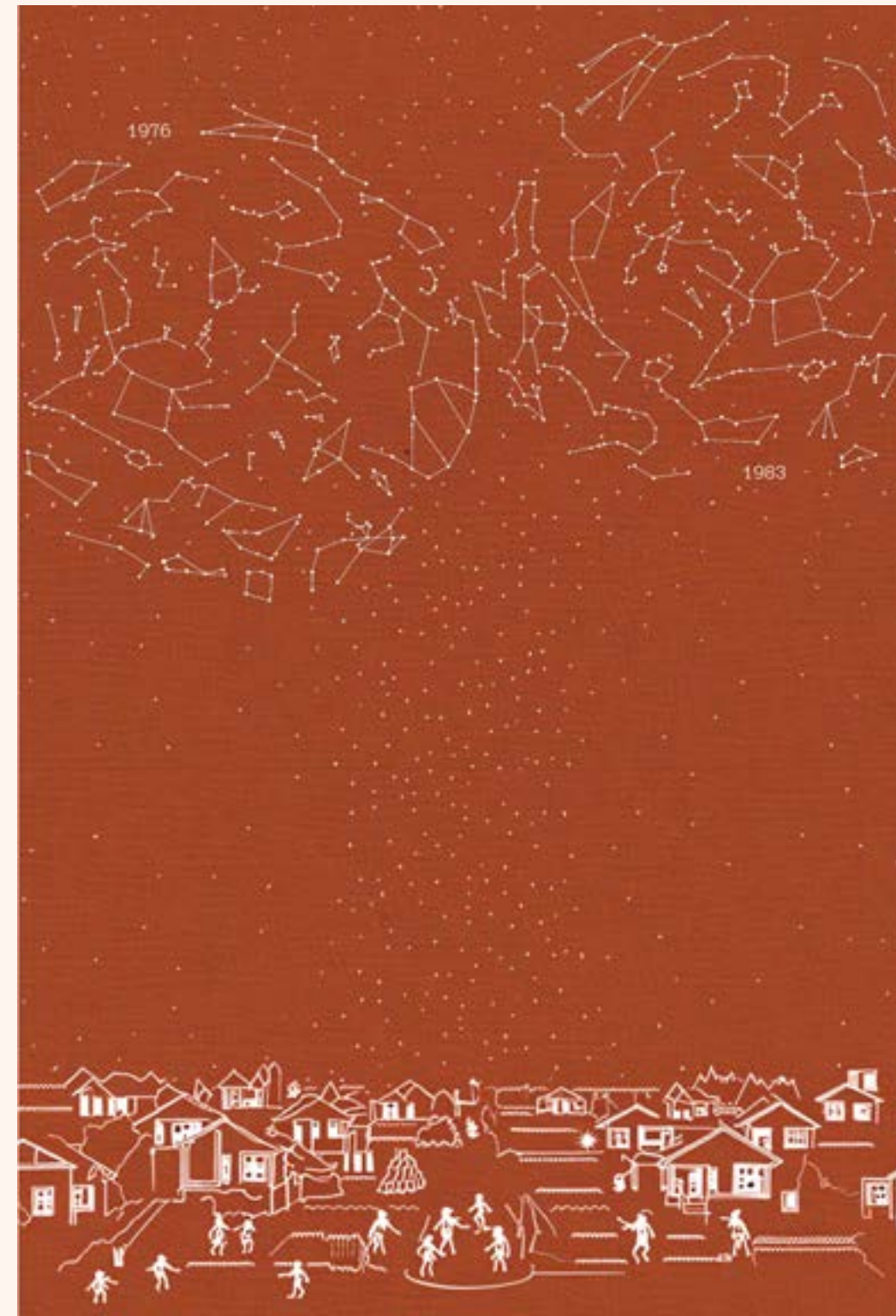
Gautham, Hemanth, Nihad

Artists' Statement

Inspired by Warli and Chittara, this work began as an exploration of how traditional visual languages could convey contemporary purpose. As I drew, I imagined Habitat for Humanity's journey—from its founding to its presence in India as constellations in the sky, each star a story, each home a promise. The patterns, symmetry and interconnected figures emerged naturally, reflecting unity, compassion and the cyclical nature of giving. For me, the process felt guided by the universe itself a dialogue between creation, service and spirituality, where every line and motif became an act of hope and connection.

Curator's Statement

Resonance of the Infinite draws on traditional Indian folk art—primarily Warli and Chittara—to explore life, community and harmony with nature. Samiksha Somani reinterprets these forms to narrate the mission of Habitat for Humanity, centering the work on two constellations: 1976, the founding of Habitat for Humanity and 1983, the establishment of Habitat India. Through symmetrical patterns, interconnected figures and recurring motifs, the artwork reflects unity, shared responsibility and the cyclical nature of giving and receiving. Houses and human forms embody Habitat's mission to build both homes and hope, while the celestial symbolism conveys the karmic and spiritual dimensions of service. The work envisions construction as an act of creation and compassion a higher purpose where every star, home and figure is a manifestation of faith, grace and enduring connection.





The story of Habitat for Humanity India:
building hope since *1983*



It all began with **One Home**

In 1983, Rev. David Rowe, the then President of Habitat for Humanity International, travelled to India to seek a place to start the first Habitat project in the Asia Pacific Region. During his visit, he was invited to Khammam, in Andhra Pradesh by Rev. Azariah Korabandi. This visit ultimately resulted in the development of the very first Habitat programme in India and the Asia-Pacific region, with K. Azariah leading operations.

In September 1983, a proposal for 65 houses in Khammam was approved by the International Board of Directors of Habitat. The program that started in Khammam grew steadily. Since then, Habitat has served more than 1.5 million families in India and an estimated 7.7* million individuals across the country.

Fatima Bibi and Gunde Venkulu were among the first few families who built their homes with Habitat for Humanity India.

*Number of families and individuals served includes the total number of households and people served by Habitat for Humanity India and Habitat's network organisations MicroBuild India and The Terwilliger Center for Innovation in Shelter in India.



Fatima Bibi

Khammam, Andhra Pradesh

"Every year our mother used to save money to repair the roof with palm leaves. She used to cook before leaving for work. However, in the absence of a door, dogs used to enter the house and eat all the food. By the time we reached home from school, there would be no food", reminisces Hussain, Fatima's son. "Mr. Azariah was like God to us and Habitat is like a temple", Hussain further adds.

Today Fatima is no more. All her children are married and have found stability in life. Hussain is a teacher. He and his wife are blessed with two children. They live happily in the home built by Habitat for Humanity India.

Gunde Venkulu

Khammam, Andhra Pradesh

"We previously had a very small hut built with mud walls and a very low thatched roof made from palm leaves and grass. It was an insecure place to live, especially for my three children. In those days I used to be a rickshaw puller earning very little income. If not for this home, perhaps we would have stayed in the same hut. I'm very grateful to Habitat for this blessing!"

Over the last four decades, Habitat for Humanity India has been a catalyst for such transformations.

Impact Numbers & Data



Since 1983, Habitat for Humanity India has helped more than

15,64,688

families build or improve the place they call home.



78,23,440

people moved into safe, decent homes through Habitat for Humanity India's support.



15,31,134

individuals supported through Housing Disaster Resilience and Response initiatives.



More than

50,000

students gained access to improved sanitation facilities and hygiene education in their schools.



3,49,375

people benefitted from household sanitation units built to ensure safety, health and dignity.



800+

households and

230+

schools gained access to clean, renewable solar energy.



Over

300

low-income families supported through housing and related interventions through the past six editions of the charity golf tournaments.



33,398

homes built.



23,385

homes repaired.



490

homes built through Housing Support Services.



1,91,984

young people joined the Habitat Young Leaders Build campaign to raise awareness about the importance of safe housing.



1,18,645

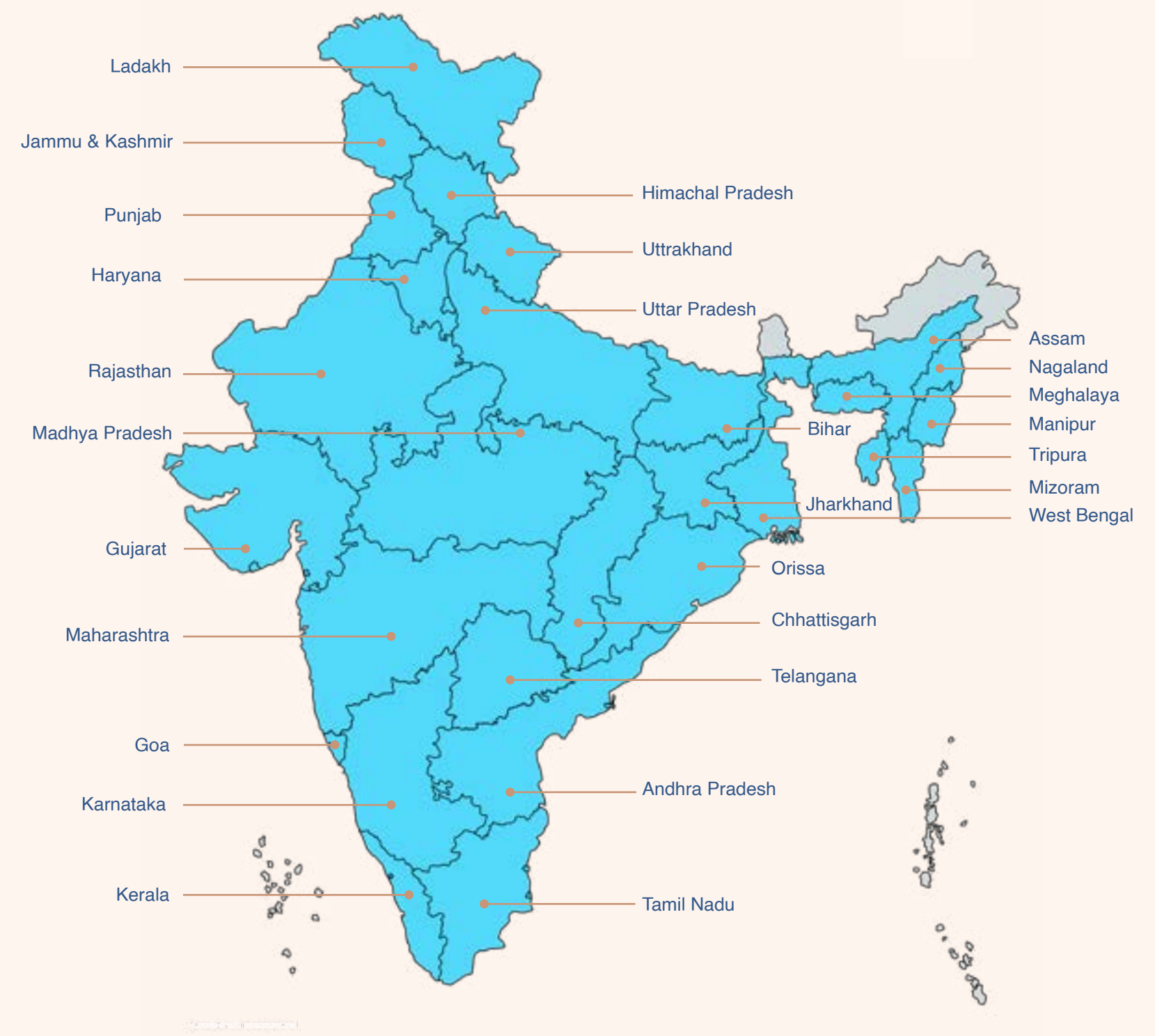
runners laced up in support of Habitat India's mission through virtual and on-ground Marathons.

BY THE NUMBERS
(as on 30th September 2025)

(*Number of families helped build or improve homes and number of people move into safe, decent homes includes the number of families helped build or improve homes and number of people move into safe, decent homes by Habitat for Humanity India and Habitat's network organisations Micro Build India and The Terwilliger Center for Innovation in Shelter in India. The data from Micro Build India and The Terwilliger Center for Innovation in Shelter in India is only till 30th June 2025.)

Our Reach *in* India over the years

Note: The illustration denotes the states where Habitat for Humanity India has worked till date. Currently Habitat is present in Delhi NCT, Haryana, Rajasthan, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Odisha, West Bengal, Assam, Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand.



Note: The map is not to scale.





Empowering futures

Dr. Belinda Bennet

Trustee – Habitat for Humanity India

Building a home is about more than shelter. It is about creating a foundation for opportunity, resilience and hope.

I am inspired by the work Habitat for Humanity India does in partnership with families, transforming lives through safe and secure housing. These homes open doors to better health, education and livelihoods, while fostering stronger communities and long-term empowerment. Every project is a chance to support families in achieving independence and building a future they can shape with confidence.

As we look to the future, we are committed to explore new ways to broaden our impact through innovative partnerships, community-led solutions and programmes that strengthen both families and neighborhoods. Our mission is clear: to build homes, communities and hope.

Together, we are building empowered communities and a future where every family can truly belong.



Every project is a chance to support families in achieving independence and building a future they can shape with confidence.



Service built on passion and precision

Air Vice Marshal

Samuel M. Nicodemus (Retd.)

Trustee – Habitat for Humanity India

During my 36 years in the Indian Air Force, from peacekeeping missions to scientific expeditions, I learned that success of each mission depends on meticulous planning, steadfast commitment and seamless collaboration across diverse teams.

Today, as we celebrate Habitat for Humanity India's journey since 1983, I see these same principles guiding its work. Habitat India partners with families not only to build homes but to create a foundation for brighter, more secure futures. Every project reflects the same passion, precision and dedication that underpin effective service to the nation.

I am proud to support Habitat India as it continues to expand its reach and impact. Together, we can ensure that more families in remote and underserved communities experience the stability, dignity and opportunity that a safe home provides.



Success of each mission depends on meticulous planning, steadfast commitment and seamless collaboration across diverse teams.



Courage lights the way

Mrs. Rajni Basumatary

Trustee – Habitat for Humanity India

Safe and secure housing is the foundation upon which families build their lives, dreams and aspirations. Habitat for Humanity India empowers families to transform not just their homes, but their futures and communities.

Through its holistic approach, Habitat India ensures that families living in vulnerable or underserved areas gain stability, dignity and the opportunity to thrive. Every home constructed reflects resilience, hope and the collective effort of volunteers, donors and partners who share a commitment to creating lasting change.

I am inspired by the courage of the families we serve and the dedication of those who work tirelessly to make these homes a reality. Each house is a stepping stone towards a better and stronger future.

I am proud to support Habitat India's mission and its vision of a world where everyone has a decent place to live. Together, we continue to build homes and futures filled with hope, security and opportunity.

Every home constructed reflects resilience, hope and the collective effort of volunteers, donors and partners who share a commitment to creating lasting change.



Helping communities thrive with dignity

Dr. Chinnababu Sunkavalli

Trustee – Habitat for Humanity India

A safe and secure home is more than shelter, it is the foundation for health, wellbeing and opportunity. In my experience as a Surgical Oncologist, I have seen how inadequate housing can directly affect physical and mental health, particularly for children, the elderly and vulnerable communities. Habitat for Humanity India addresses this critical connection by ensuring that families live in safe, resilient and dignified homes.

Through its work, Habitat India builds hope, stability and stronger communities. Families who once faced the constant stress of unsafe or temporary housing are now able to focus on education, livelihoods and health. The organisation's holistic approach combining resilience, accessibility and community engagement, creates lasting impact, empowering people to thrive rather than merely survive.

As a Trustee, I am proud to support Habitat India's mission and witness the transformation that safe housing brings to individuals and communities alike. Every home built is a step towards healthier, more secure and more empowered lives and I am inspired by the dedication and compassion of all those who make this possible.

The organisation's holistic approach combining resilience, accessibility and community engagement, creates lasting impact, empowering people to thrive rather than merely survive.



Empowerment through stability

Mr. Rajeev Menon

Strategic Advisor - Habitat for Humanity India
Managing Partner - Catalyst Solutions PTE

As Habitat India marks over four decades of service, I am reminded of the enduring value of a home. While food and clothing meet immediate needs, it is a safe shelter — a true home — that creates a foundation for lasting security, education and opportunity.

Through initiatives like the annual Habitat Charity Golf Tournament, India's golfing community — industry and business leaders — has rallied to build homes for families in need. Over six editions of Habitat Golf tournament and many more to come across India, we have helped more than 300 low-income families gain stability and hope.

It is an honour to support Habitat for Humanity India's work. By empowering families with decent housing, we help break the cycle of poverty and create lasting change. Together, we can ensure every family has not just a roof, but dignity and opportunity for a better future.



It is a safe shelter — a true home — that creates a foundation for lasting security, education and opportunity.



Building an equitable nation

Mr. Shirish Damle

Strategic Advisor - Habitat for Humanity India
Head India CSC - Treasury and Trade Solutions Client Operations, CSIPL Citibank India

My association with Habitat for Humanity India has been one of deep learning and fulfilment. Over the years, I have witnessed the passion and integrity with which Habitat carries forward its mission uniting people from all walks of life to build homes, communities and hope. It has been an honour to contribute to this journey and to work alongside like-minded individuals who believe that everyone deserves a decent place to live.

As Habitat for Humanity India celebrates over four decades of impact and two decades of the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee, I take pride in having been part of this collective effort one that continues to build a stronger, more equitable India.



Over the years, I have witnessed the passion and integrity with which Habitat carries forward its mission uniting people from all walks of life to build homes, communities and hope.



IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee :
years of vision and impact *20*



IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee

The Genesis

The year was 2005. On 2nd October, the day celebrated for the birth of Father of the Nation Mahatma Gandhi and the day before World Habitat Day, leaders from India's renowned corporate organisations gathered to announce the launch of Habitat for Humanity India's IndiaBUILDS Campaign.

It began an ambitious five-year campaign, highlighting the dire need for decent housing among millions of underprivileged families in the country.

But more importantly, each one of these eminent businessmen and women came together to form the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee of Habitat India an influential circle of individuals who began to guide and add value to Habitat India's growth and overall journey from that day forth.

Their first large-scale initiative of building homes with 100 homeowners, alongside former President of the USA late Jimmy Carter and former late First Lady Rosalynn Carter for the annual international Jimmy Carter Work Project in October 2006 solidified their resolve to work towards a larger, more powerful goal: to eliminate barriers to a better, healthier and more financially stable life.

Through their expertise, leadership, knowledge, counsel and network, the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee has served Habitat for Humanity India for the last 20 years, working with resolve and passion, lending their voice, reputation and financial assistance to the vision of a world where everyone has a decent place to live.





Leadership through
Partnership



Our work with Aditya Birla Group

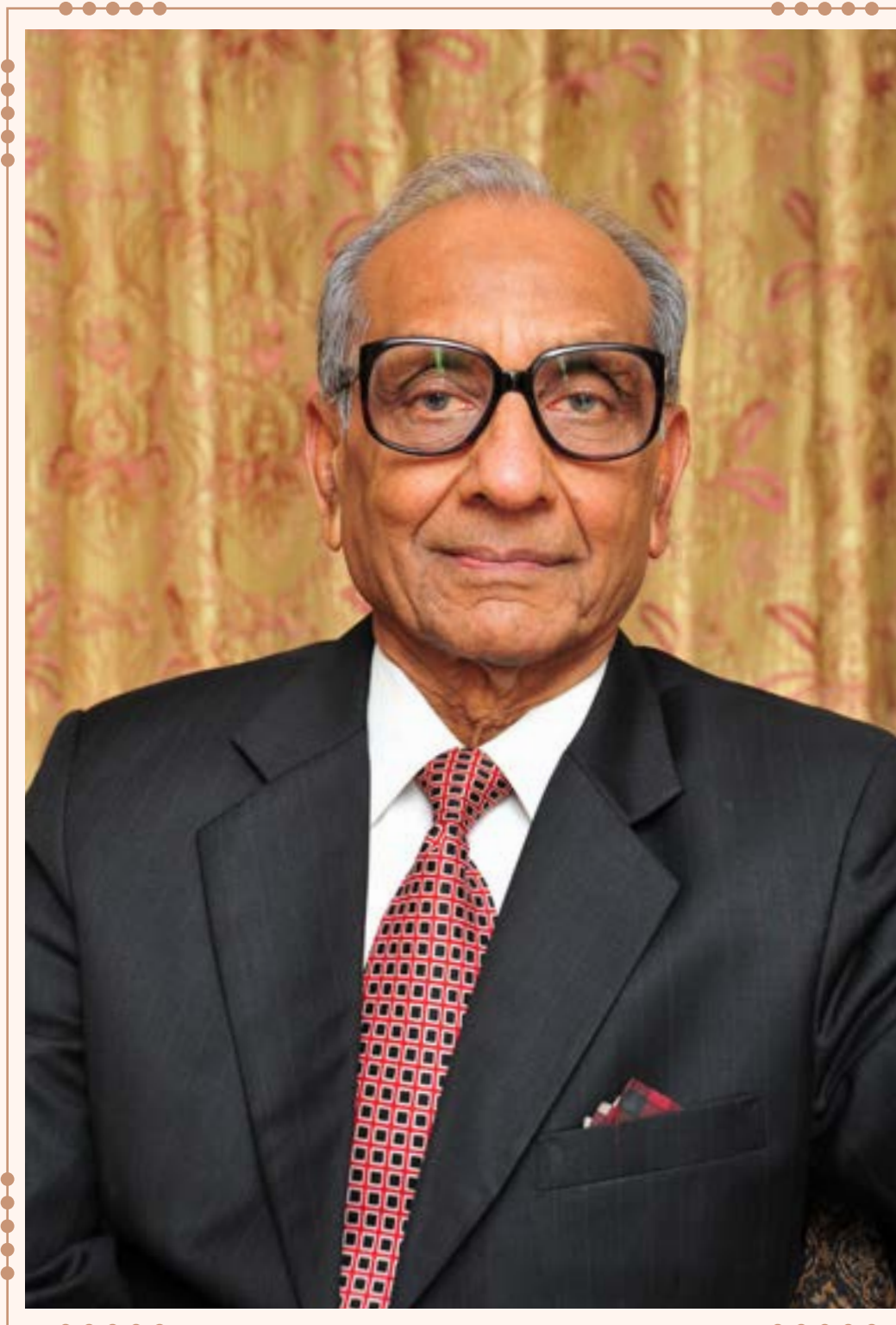
Our partnership with Aditya Birla Group dates back to 2001-02; nearly 25 years ago thanks to the first housing project supported by HINDALCO in Renukoot, Uttar Pradesh. A total of 110 homes were built with a proportion of resources mobilised by the Aditya Birla Group. Mrs. Rajashree Birla, Mr. Askaran Agarwala and Dr. Pragnya Ram played an important role in nurturing the partnership between the Aditya Birla Group and Habitat India.

Subsequently, the partnership extended to other countries in the Asia Pacific region. Mrs. Rajashree Birla has played an integral role in the formation and growth of the Habitat for Humanity India's IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee and has also brought several thought leaders and influential personalities from different business sectors to join and enrich the Committee. Mrs. Birla is also the esteemed member of the Asia Pacific Development Council of Habitat for Humanity International.

Partnership Highlights

- Over 4,000 homes built in India, Japan, Philippines, South Korea and Thailand.
- Sanitation Units Built: 2,941
- Community Facilities: 2
- Supported disaster affected families in the aftermath of Indian Ocean Tsunami 2004, Uttarakhand floods 2013-14 and Jammu and Kashmir floods 2015-16
- Supported the Carter Work Project in India (2006) to build homes with 100 low-income families in Lonavala, Maharashtra and the Carter Work Project in Mekong (2009)
- Supported Habitat for Humanity's Asia-Pacific Housing Forums
- Supported Habitat for Humanity India's charity events under the aegis of IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee in India, Dubai (UAE), London (UK) and New York (USA)





Creating access to safe housing

MR. ASKARAN AGARWALA

Group Advisor - Birla Group Trusts and
Special Community Projects

Habitat for Humanity India's mission aligns closely with the Government of India's vision of 'Housing for All'. As Habitat India marks this important milestone in its journey, it stands as a testament to what collaboration and compassion can achieve. Habitat's goal to build strength, stability and self-reliance in families across India through shelter and sanitation is not only building hope but also transforming lives.

By engaging key stakeholders, we can multiply the reach and impact of Habitat India's housing initiatives ensuring that more families have access to safe and dignified homes. I remember the early days of Habitat India's humble beginnings and under the leadership of Mrs. Rajashree Birla, I look forward to seeing the organisation continue to build on its strong foundation and reach even greater heights in the years ahead.

Habitat's goal to build
strength, stability
and self-reliance in
families across India
through shelter and
sanitation is not only
building hope but also
transforming lives



Community Development through housing

When we visited the villages and met with the rural folks who lived from day to day to assess their needs for a shelter, they spoke in a tone of exhaustion for they felt nothing inside except a sense of emptiness, and of wounded lives with a low burning rage.

Dr. Pragnya Ram

Group Executive President; Group Head - CSR, Legacy Documentation and Archives, Aditya Birla Group

Much to smile about: Our tryst with Habitat

Rewind to the late 1990s. It seems like only yesterday that our Chairperson, Mrs. Rajashreeji Birla, sat us down with a considerable amount of stoicism. With a callout for greater empathy to counteract the forces of inequity. Of these housing woes were the most shocking among the underprivileged. Millions lived without a shelter on their heads. In the wake of these circumstances, one found among Rajashreeji her sense of destination, her vision for homes for the poor.

So, we set out to explore the ground realities in some of the villages in proximity to our plants. Time is an excellent filter of memories and emotions once experienced. When we visited the villages and met with the rural folks who lived from day to day to assess their needs for a shelter, they spoke in a tone of exhaustion for they felt nothing inside except a sense of emptiness, and of wounded lives with a low burning rage.

It was indeed opportune to have Habitat for Humanity on the horizon loom large before us. So backed by our Northern Star, Mrs. Birla, we made a pitch to Hindalco along with Mr. Rick Hathway and the Habitat team. Mr. Askaranji Agarwala, the benevolent head of Hindalco readily acquiesced, so we marched back happy. Our first set of 110 houses were built in the Dudhi block, a hamlet close to Hindalco's plant in Renukoot, Uttar Pradesh.

Since then, every decade has witnessed the rise of more houses, with innovation and newness textured in the structures. Today, walking in step with Habitat, tens of thousands of homes have been built and renovated. Housing tribal communities, war widows, widows of farmers and the disadvantaged differently abled among others. Together we have created a new zone for their lives.

When the houses were handed over to them, the optics changed remarkably. Some privacy. Homes electrified for their children to study. A great sense of ownership. They suddenly felt inclusive. There was hope and joy in their eyes. They felt a sense of dignity, that they too could dream of a future as their lives were unyoked from their former tribulations. Not surprising then, that they look upon us as a Force for Good as we boarded them on a great transformative, life changing journey. What more can one say!



Building self-reliance

Mr. Samir Agarwal

Senior Vice President, Aditya Birla Group

For over twenty-five years, our journey with Habitat for Humanity India has been one of building more than walls and roofs — we have helped build dreams, dignity and the quiet strength that comes from having a place to call one's own.

Guided by the luminous vision of Mrs. Rajashree Birla and steadfastly supported by Mr. Askaran Agarwala, Dr. (Mrs.) Pragnya Ram and our senior leadership, this partnership has grown into a living testament to what compassion, collaboration and conviction can achieve together.

As Habitat for Humanity India celebrates over four decades of transforming lives and marks twenty inspiring years of the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee, we at the Aditya Birla Group reaffirm our deep and enduring commitment to this noble mission: to build homes, nurture communities and inspire hope for a brighter, better tomorrow.

*For in every home built, a future begins.
In every foundation laid, a dream takes root.
And in every heart touched, hope finds a home.*

We have helped build dreams, dignity and the quiet strength that comes from having a place to call one's own.



Overcoming the wrath of seeping rainwater

Khandu Wagh Igatpuri, Maharashtra

“Every year, we would gather karvi, plaster the hut with cow dung and cover it with a plastic sheet when the rains came. But no matter what we did, storms would tear it apart,” says Khandu.

For nearly half a century, Khandu and his wife, Pokalabai, struggled to maintain their fragile existence in Ubhade Village in Igatpuri block, Nasik District, Maharashtra. They lived in a Karvi hut - traditional house in Maharashtra, built using Karvi plants and cow dung or mud. However, the couple's home, made of sticks, cow dung and plastic, barely stood up to the challenges of the monsoon season. “We had no place we could truly call home,” recalls Pokalabai.

Each rainy season brought new anxieties. Rainwater seeped through the roof and the walls often turned to mush, forcing them to rebuild time and again. “We could see snakes slipping into our blankets,” shares Pokalabai.

“With no electricity, we had to rely on a small oil lamp to spot them. The cost of the oil felt like burning through our savings, but darkness brought its own fears.”

Preparing their hut each year required immense effort. Before the rains, they trekked through forests and mountains to collect cow dung for plastering. “Villagers wouldn't let us use dung from their cattle,” says Pokalabai. “We often had to follow buffalo herds for miles, just to scrape together enough. When that failed, we had to buy a bucket of dung for 50 rupees—a steep price for us.”

Khandu, a daily wage labourer earning just 200 rupees per day, struggled to provide for his family. “Whatever we earned was barely enough to survive,” he explains. Meanwhile, Pokalabai had no private space for bathing. “I felt so humiliated when villagers walked by as I bathed,” she says. “There was no bathroom—only the mountain for privacy.”

Their children grew up enduring similar hardships. “They had to gather firewood from the forest because no one let us collect even a fallen branch,” remembers Khandu. Fierce storms would often blow away their roof's plastic sheets, leaving them exposed to the elements.

This cycle of struggle ended when Habitat India stepped in. The family now lives in a solid, concrete home equipped with solar lights, piped water and, to Pokalabai's relief, an in-house bathroom. “This is not just a house,” says Khandu with a broad smile. “It is a blessing—a true home we never dared dream of.”

The house offers them dignity, safety and security. The family's health has also improved. “Before, we were always sick,” says Pokalabai. “Living in damp, unsanitary conditions gave us fevers and coughs. Now, it feels as though those illnesses disappeared the day we stepped into this house.”

The new home, featuring an RCC roof, strategically placed windows for ventilation and solar panels for sustainable energy, has transformed their lives. “I worked alongside Habitat India from the foundation up,” says Pokalabai proudly. “I even helped lay the bricks. This house is a legacy for our children, built with our own hands.”

The children now sleep safely within sturdy walls, no longer facing the threat of snakes or insects. The family now enjoys the comfort of a 300 sq. ft. house, complete with a bedroom, kitchen, hall and bathroom. “This home is not just for us—it is for the generations to come,” says Khandu. “Our children can grow up with safety and dignity here. The struggles of the past are over.”

This project supported by Aditya Birla Group in 2024 has helped Habitat for Humanity India build homes for 11 tribal families and sanitation units for 3 schools.



*Stronger
Together*

Each home
constructed
becomes a
foundation for
better health,
education
and economic
opportunity.

Mr. Asit Koticha

Chief Investor and Promoter - Jean Claude Biguine Salon & Spa,
Pashmina Developers
Member - IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee,
Habitat for Humanity India

Together, we build on a legacy of partnership and impact that spans four decades. Since Habitat for Humanity India's first home in 1983, the movement for housing has come a long way. We have partnered with families, communities and visionary supporters to create more than houses — we have built hope, opportunity and economic progress for generations.

My journey alongside Habitat has been deeply fulfilling. It began with initiatives like the 'Pashmina House-for-a-house' campaign where our donation in 2007 facilitated and built over 2000 homes in Karjat (Raigad district, Maharashtra). I proposed the formation of MicroBuild India to accelerate the cause, with my equity, which now enables countless low-income families to access financial support for home improvements. I am blessed to see how these collective efforts have transformed lives. Each home constructed becomes a foundation for better health, education and economic opportunity.

My association with Habitat deepened in 2008, with key initiatives that brought global attention to the cause of affordable housing — especially with the campaign of John Abraham, which created long-lasting impact through collaboration.

Habitat for Humanity builds lives. It is an organisation that recognises the need to safeguard the interest of the women, the children and the entire society. Putting India on the global map while recognising the deep-rooted effect an experience has on donors, Habitat inspires via experience. Whether the experience is Global, where we worked alongside the former US President, Jimmy Carter or local, where my daughter had her first experience via her school – it makes an impact.

My wife, Kanan and my daughter, Sneha, have been active participants in the Women India Builds initiative, proving that when we build together as a family, we inspire the next generation of leaders and change-makers.

As we celebrate 20 years of the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee and mark Habitat India's 42-years of impact, I am proud of what we have achieved and feel energised by what lies ahead. Under the leadership of Mrs. Rajashree Birla at the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee, we continue building homes, communities and futures.



Mrs. Kanan Koticha

Women IndiaBUILDS is an organisation where women build women and their future. Where a simple act of giving can empower families to build safer, stronger lives; it is the joy of seeing women lead change that inspires me.

Ms. Sneha Koticha

Managing Director, Jean Claude Biguine - Salon & Spa

A simple experience during a build activity in school, left a deep-rooted impact on me that stayed with me for life. Every "Habitat Build" builds a lifelong experience of character. It has always been a privilege to be a part of a cause that turns compassion into action, while impacting society and economy. It is a vision to inspire the burgeoning youth of the nation to be a part of Habitats vision where every person has a decent place to live.



Harnessing the power of togetherness

By innovating our approaches, forging deeper partnerships and harnessing our collective will, we can bring decent homes within reach of underprivileged families who are living in substandard housing conditions.

Mr. Sanjay Nayar

Founder and Chairman – Sorin

Member – IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee

As Habitat for Humanity India celebrates 42 years of transforming lives and 20 years of the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee, I am proud of how far we have come and excited by the impact we can achieve next.

Housing is the bedrock upon which economic growth stands. Guided by strong governance, visionary leadership and a proven track record, Habitat India is poised to scale its impact exponentially. By innovating our approaches, forging deeper partnerships and harnessing our collective will, we can bring decent homes within reach of underprivileged families who are living in substandard housing conditions.

Reflecting on my own journey, I am reminded of the Carter Work Project in Lonavala (Maharashtra) in 2006 led by the former President of the U.S.A late Jimmy Carter and former First lady late Rosalynn Carter. I was touched by their humility and service. Alongside fellow volunteers, I laid bricks and shared meals with the families while helping them building their new homes.

I remember during the Build; we were enthusiastically leading a group of volunteers to construct one of the shelters. After six hours of hard work, we thought we had done a fantastic job until one of the construction experts came by and in a minute, dismantled everything, saying it was hardly a shelter. Watching him rebuild it perfectly was a memorable experience. What stood out most to me though was the incredible enthusiasm of everyone involved and the way the Habitat India built momentum and spirit around the entire effort. That hands-on experience brought home the transformative power of “building together”. When we work with homeowners, we lay the groundwork for lasting change.

It has been a privilege to serve on the Advisory Committee and witness firsthand the impact created by Habitat. As we look ahead, I do so with unwavering hope and determination. Together, we can continue to transform lives. I urge fellow leaders from corporate India and support this life changing movement.



Collective strength for lasting change

The joy and gratitude on the families’ faces remain etched in my memory. Each partnership has reaffirmed my belief in the power of collective action to create change.

Mr. Gul Kripalani

Chairman and Managing Director - Pijikay Group of Companies

Member – IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee

My association with Habitat for Humanity India goes back to the formation of the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee in 2006. It has been a deeply fulfilling journey one marked by collaboration, compassion and a shared vision to build a better India through safe and affordable housing.

Over the years, I have had the privilege of connecting Habitat India with many institutions and personalities who went on to champion the cause of housing. I particularly remember my first project of building homes in partnership with Rotary Club of Bombay in 2006 in Mahad, Maharashtra. The joy and gratitude on the families’ faces remain etched in my memory. Each partnership has reaffirmed my belief in the power of collective action to create lasting change.

Among my most cherished memories is the Carter Work Project in Lonavala in 2006, where I had the honour of building alongside former President of the U.S.A. late Jimmy Carter and former First lady of the U.S.A late Rosalynn Carter and other passionate volunteers. That experience was humbling and transformative a reminder of what humanity can achieve when rising above caste and creed, united in a common purpose.

As we celebrate over four decades of Habitat India’s work and 20 years of the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee, under the leadership of Smt. Rajashree Birla, my dream is to see the organisation scale even greater heights, multiplying its impact and bringing us closer to a future where every family has a place to call home.



Transformational power of housing

Dr. Niranjan Hiranandani

Managing Director – Hiranandani Group of Companies
Chairman – NAREDCO National
Member – IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee,
Habitat for Humanity India

Housing has always held a special place in my heart because I have seen first-hand how it transforms lives. A home is not just about walls and a roof - it is the foundation for a better life.

It is in this spirit that I value my association with Habitat for Humanity India and the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee. It has been an absolute honour to be part of this journey and to witness how Habitat's work has impacted the lives of thousands of families across the country.

As India moves forward with the ambitious vision of Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana 2.0, there lies a tremendous opportunity for Habitat India to align its initiatives with the objectives of the national housing mission to ensure "Housing for All".

In addition, Habitat's Housing Support Services model offers a pathway to address two critical needs at once — improving the quality of housing and creating livelihood opportunities through upskilling. By scaling up this model, Habitat India can make a significant impact not only on homes but also on lives, equipping individuals with the skills needed to participate meaningfully in the housing ecosystem.

Our mission also resonates deeply with the broader national aspiration of "Viksit Bharat"— Government of India's ambitious vision to transform the nation into a developed country by 2047, coinciding with the centennial of its independence, encompassing economic prosperity, social advancement, environmental sustainability and effective governance.

As we mark this milestone, my message is one of confidence and hope. Habitat India is well positioned to continue making a lasting difference. I look forward to seeing its impact grow, brick by brick.

By scaling up this model, Habitat India can make a significant impact not only on homes but also on lives, equipping individuals with the skills needed to participate meaningfully in the housing ecosystem.



Building homes today to empower future

Ms. Elina Meswani

Philanthropist
Member – IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee

For me, the power of a home goes far beyond shelter. A safe and stable home lays the foundation for women to thrive, children to grow and families to flourish.

When women feel secure, they are able to educate their children, care for their families, manage their households better and pursue meaningful livelihoods. A secure home gives women the confidence to participate in decision-making both within their families and their communities. Each home built becomes a space where dignity, hope and opportunity take root.

I am proud to be part of Habitat for Humanity India's journey, helping create homes that empower women, strengthen families and inspire communities to dream bigger and achieve more.

A secure home gives women the confidence to participate in decision-making both within their families and their communities.



Delivering the needs of communities

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In many ways, building homes is an investment in people their lives, their potential and their future. It is an investment that yields returns far beyond financial metrics, creating lasting social impact.

Mr. Nikhil Srivastava

Partner, Co-Head of Private Equity - PAG
Member – IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee

Housing is more than just four walls; it is the foundation upon which families build their futures. For communities to truly thrive, housing must be part of a larger ecosystem that nurtures livelihoods, health and well-being. This is where collaboration becomes essential.

Habitat for Humanity India has a unique ability to understand the needs of communities and deliver sustainable housing solutions. In many ways, building homes is an investment in people their lives, their potential and their future. It is an investment that yields returns far beyond financial metrics, creating lasting social impact.

Over the years, it has been both exciting and deeply rewarding to be part of the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee, to contribute through initiatives such as the Habitat Charity Golf Tournament and to witness firsthand the meaningful work Habitat India continues to do across the country. I look forward to seeing how our collective efforts can further empower communities and support India's journey toward inclusive growth and opportunity for all.



Pathways to growth

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What stands out for me about Habitat is its holistic approach, building not just homes, but pathways for families to grow and thrive.

Mr. Jitendra Gupta

Founder and Chief Executive Officer - Jupiter (Amica Financial),
Ex-Citrus Pay and Ex-LazyPay
Member – IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee

My association with Habitat for Humanity India started in 2024. Joining the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee gave me a firsthand view of the powerful work being done to address India's housing challenges. It reaffirmed a simple truth, a home isn't just a structure; it's the foundation for dignity, opportunity and hope.

What stands out for me about Habitat is its holistic approach, building not just homes, but pathways for families to grow and thrive. A secure home opens doors to better livelihoods and helps people take charge of their future.

As we celebrate 20 years of the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee, I feel privileged to be part of this journey. The challenges ahead are large, but so are the opportunities. With collaboration, innovation and shared intent, we can continue to make a real difference, one home, one family at a time.



*Tangible contribution
towards humanity*

Mr. Siddhartha Ghosal

CEO and Country President - Dow India
Member - IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee

It is truly inspiring to see how the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee has advanced the cause of housing over the past two decades building homes, strengthening communities and transforming lives across India.

Habitat for Humanity India's work of building safe, dignified homes for families resonates deeply with me. Dow India is proud to have partnered with Habitat India to support its vision of a world where everyone has a decent place to live. Our collaboration has extended beyond constructing homes it has been about nurturing thriving, resilient communities.

Through multiple initiatives, we have helped build homes, sanitation units and clean water facilities that have brought tangible improvements to the lives of families across Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu.

As we look ahead, Dow India remains committed to deepening its association with Habitat for Humanity India to create sustainable impact — empowering communities, fostering inclusive growth and building a future where every family can live with dignity.



Our collaboration
has extended
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The Jimmy and Rosalynn Carter Work Project (2006)

A Defining Moment

Every year since 1984, former U.S. President Jimmy Carter and former First Lady Rosalynn Carter have participated in a Habitat build one year in the United States and the following year somewhere around the world. This build has become the globally renowned Jimmy and Rosalynn Carter Work Project (CWP).

For over 41 years, the Carter Work Project has involved 1,08,000 volunteers across 14 countries, building, renovating and repairing 4,447 homes for families in need.

In India, the Carter Work Project was held from 29th October to 3rd November 2006 in Lonavala, Maharashtra. It was the first major event organised with the support of the newly formed Habitat IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee.

More than 3,000 volunteers from over 30 countries came together to complete 100 homes in just five days, working

alongside President and Mrs. Carter. The CWP also marked the launch of Habitat's IndiaBUILDS Campaign an ambitious initiative aimed at providing housing solutions for 250,000 people over the next five years.

A number of celebrities including Brad Pitt, Steve Waugh, John Abraham, Pooja Bedi and Diana Hayden, among others joined hands with Habitat homeowners to help them build their dream homes.

Corporate partners supporting the effort included Aditya Birla Group, Cisco, Citi Group, The Dow Chemical Company, HDFC, Lehman Brothers, The Maersk Group, Masco Corporation, POSCO India, Reliance, Vedanta and Whirlpool, among others.

The legacy left behind by the Carters and the renowned members of the Habitat IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee continues to live on in the lives of the families in Lonavala and in every volunteer who worked to build a better India.



Gone, But Not Forgotten

President Carter and Mrs. Rosalynn Carter's Legacy of Building Homes and Lives

In 2023 and 2024 Habitat for Humanity India bid farewell to extraordinary leaders and humanitarians - Jimmy Carter, former President of the U.S.A and his wife Mrs. Rosalynn Carter, former First lady. Their life's work - rooted in social justice, human rights and faith has left an indelible mark on the world.

For over 41 years, President Carter, alongside former First Lady late Rosalynn Carter, led the Jimmy & Rosalynn Carter Work Project with Habitat for Humanity. This initiative mobilised 1,08,100 volunteers to build, renovate and repair 4,447 homes in 14 countries, raising awareness about the global need for affordable housing.

In October 2006, Habitat for Humanity India had the privilege of hosting The Carter Work Project in Lonavala, Pune, where President Carter and Mrs. Rosalynn Carter led over 3000 volunteers to build 100 homes in partnership with low-income families, symbolising hope and stability for families in need of safe and decent homes.

President Carter's legacy of compassion and service remains a guiding light not only in the houses he helped build, but in the volunteers he inspired to follow his example. Along with Mrs. Carter, he illustrated, with joy and dedication, the idea that everyone can play a part in creating a world where everyone has a decent place to live.





Malan Baiker

Lonavala, Maharashtra

“Earlier, I had to walk 20 minutes just to fetch water. We had no toilet and at night I was scared to go into the jungle. My old house was located in such a remote area that no doctor would come. I lost my son because we could not get medical treatment or care in time.

Moving into my Habitat home in 2006 changed everything. Here, I began tailoring clothes and rebuilding my life. I still remember when many foreigners came to help as volunteers, among them was a tall, elderly man in a checked shirt and jeans. He wore gloves and laid bricks for my home with a smile on his face. Later, I learned he was the former President of the U.S.A. I feel sad that he is no more, but my home carries the memory of his kindness in every wall”, said Malan when she learnt about the President’s passing.

Malan is one of the 100 homeowners who built their homes alongside President and Mrs. Carter and over 3000 volunteers through The Carter Work Project in 2006 in Lonavala, Pune district Maharashtra.



Habitat's Terwilliger Center for Innovation in Shelter

There is tremendous untapped potential - within both the demand and supply sides of housing markets - that, if addressed, could substantially improve housing availability and quality.

Habitat for Humanity's Terwilliger Center for Innovation in Shelter focuses on the most pivotal but uncharted interventions in global housing markets. We conceptualize, pilot and accelerate solutions that have the greatest potential to close the affordable housing deficit for low-income communities.

In India, the Terwilliger Center works to expand access to innovative and quality services, products and financing so that households can improve their shelter more effectively and efficiently. By engaging and partnering with housing market actors – financial institutions, manufacturers, retailers, startups, academic

institutions and civil society organizations, among others – we strive to build inclusive housing markets that better address the needs of low-income families.

A key focus of the Center's work lies in identifying disruptive technologies and exploring ways to bring them into the low-income housing market. An example of this approach is the incubation support to Tvasta, an innovative startup and developer of 3D printing technology for construction. Our partnership and investment allowed Tvasta to build a model house to help validate the solution and demonstrate the firm's capability for handling larger housing projects.

Note: The photograph shows the model house built by Tvasta in 2021 using a catalytic grant provided by the Terwilliger Center for Innovation in Shelter.



Micro Build India

Established with the vision of strengthening financial inclusion in housing, Micro Build India has steadily expanded its presence across 20 states. As of September 2025, Micro Build India, along with its partner Microfinance Institutions (MFIs) has supported 550,002 households build / repair their houses and providing them a decent place to live. Thus empowering thousands of families to complete their unfinished homes and improve their living conditions through timely, affordable loans, Micro Build India continues to bridge the gap between financial inclusion and secure shelter — transforming aspirations of homeownership into reality for low-income families across India.



Terra Accord

Digital Artist :

Samiksha Somani

Softwares Used :

Adobe Photoshop, Adobe Illustrator and Procreate

Artistic Technique :

Digital reinterpretation using layered patterns and flowing forms to express movement and community.

Design Principles :

Rhythm, Balance and Unity

Medium :

Digital illustration inspired by traditional pigments and earthy tones of Indian mural art.

Art & Craft styles :

Gond's storytelling, Saora Wall Painting from Odisha and Sohrai and Khovar Painting from Jharkhand

Curator :

Dr. Rikimi Madhukaillya

Conceptualiser & Artistic Director :

Akhil Vadehra

Craft Researchers :

Gautham, Hemanth, Nihad

Artists' Statement

The beauty of Gond, Saora, Sohrai and Khovar art moved my core, how they tell stories of life, growth and care through simple, earthy forms. While creating this piece, I felt the pulse of the earth, the rhythm of community and the quiet strength of togetherness. Each line and color carries warmth, balance and belonging. For me, this artwork is a prayer to harmony a reminder that when we build with love, we build not just homes, but life itself.

Curator's Statement

Terra Accord is inspired by traditional Indian folk art styles such as Gond storytelling, Saora wall paintings from Odisha and Sohrai and Khovar paintings from Jharkhand. Each of these art forms celebrates nature, community and the cycle of life — values that deeply connect with Habitat for Humanity's vision of building homes, hope and togetherness.

The use of symbolic shapes, organic lines and earthy tones as fascinated by samiksha somani shows harmony between people and their surroundings. The houses and figures represent the spirit of belonging and collective effort, while the flowing patterns reflect the movement of life — much like the way Habitat communities grow and evolve through shared work and care.

Through its balance, rhythm and storytelling, Terra Accord celebrates the unity of people, culture and compassion — the same values that guide Habitat for Humanity's work across the world.





Stories of *Transformation*



Chaya threads her own future, stitch by stitch

Chaya Shete

Pune, Maharashtra

Chaya turned a single sewing machine and a low-paying job into a life that protects her daughters and lets them dream.

Chaya settles on her sewing machine; a length of deep-green cloth draped across her lap. She lines the edges, presses the pedal and the needle begins with its quick, steady song. On a small table to her left sits a pile of finished blouses, threads trimmed and seams straight. “When I sew, I feel calm,” she says. “The cloth listens. It does what I ask. Life outside is not always like that.”

Thirteen years ago, Chaya’s husband took his own life. He had struggled with alcohol and gambling, moving from job to job until nothing held. One morning he ended his life on the family’s small farm behind their home. Chaya was twenty-eight then, with two little girls and an ageing mother-in-law. “There was no money and no one to lean on,” she says. “But I knew I had to stand, because the girls were watching.”

Armed with the knowledge of basic tailoring, a second-hand machine on loan, Chaya divided her time between Anganwadi work, stitching saris into school uniforms, along with short spells of farm labour whenever she could. “Some weeks I slept three hours a night,” she says. “I left the girls with my father or with a neighbour and ran to the factory to iron boxes. Anything that paid, I did.”

The family’s old house was a single room patched with tin. There was no kitchen; cooking happened in a smoky corner near the door. A bare bulb flickered. The toilet stood outside, covered on one side with a piece of metal sheet. Chaya sewed a curtain from an old bed sheet to give her daughters a bit of privacy. “They were scared,” she says. “At night I went with them, holding a torch.”

Her older daughter Arya, now in Class 11, remembers finishing homework under a dim lantern while her younger sister, Shreya, who is fourteen and in Class 9, nodded off beside her. “Flies would sit on our books,” Arya says. “When I visited friends with proper houses, I wished we had one too.”

Chaya partnered with Habitat for Humanity India to build her home and create a safe space for her family. She saved every extra salary from her Anganwadi job and borrowed a little more when the walls started to rise so she could furnish the house with kitchen utensils, a queen-size bed and a cupboard for her daughter’s books. She also stitched pillow covers from leftover dress pieces.

Today the family lives in a three-room cement house with a tiled kitchen, a small hall and a bedroom large enough for two beds and a steel cupboard. The toilet and bathroom sit behind a locked door; the girls no longer walk to the field at dawn. Solar lights brighten the rooms each evening. A single fan turns above the sewing machine.

Shreya likes to read here after school, the light steady on her pages. “I used to cry when the light went out and the girls could not study,” she says, smoothing the fabric under the needle. “Now I see them laughing in this bright room. I think we are moving forward, even if slowly.”

She lifts the presser foot, trims the thread and folds the garment. Outside, the afternoon sun falls on the fresh white walls of the house. The door is new, the lock clicks shut and inside those walls a mother and her daughters are piecing together a future they can call their own.



A dream realised for Nafisa and Vasim

Nafisa Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh

“My husband was often worried about whether we should focus on meeting our children’s daily needs or build a proper home. It was a difficult choice to make.”
– Nafisa, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh.

Nafisa (27), her husband Vasim (30) and their children – Farman (14), Farah (13), Sameer (10), Riyan (8) and Shifa (7), lived in a house made of mud and bricks for nine long years in Sara village of Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh. The house was built by the family when they shifted from their rental home in the same village.

Vasim does multiple jobs to earn a living for his family. He alternates between working as a daily wage labourer, truck driver and playing the banjo in a local band. Nafisa is a skilled artist who takes embroidery orders from her neighbours. Together they earn around 12,000/- to 13,000/- per month.

Living in their old house was a constant challenge for Nafisa and Vasim. “Every time it rained, the stream in front of our home would overflow and the floor of our house would be waterlogged. My children couldn’t go to school during this time and at home, they couldn’t even find a decent place to sit and study. We had to scoop the water out using buckets,” Nafisa recalls.

“The roof of our house collapsed on one of those days during the monsoon. We were terrified that our children might get trapped under the debris. We made a make-shift house for us to stay and shifted with whatever was left. It was heartbreaking to see everything that we built with our own hands getting damaged”, says Vasim.

Habitat for Humanity India partnered with Nafisa and Vasim to help them build a new home.

“When the construction started, every night, I used to think about the progress of the construction and how much we would complete the following day. I couldn’t sleep due to the anticipation and excitement. Now, I am finally sleeping peacefully. It feels like a dream that I don’t want to wake up from,” says Vasim.

Nafisa says “It was difficult to keep the old house clean. Now that we have the new home, I tell the kids to wash their feet before entering the house. I will create handmade art and decorate my entire house for Eid.”

For Nafisa and Vasim, the journey towards a decent home was not just about building walls but about building a future filled with dreams and possibilities. Their new home is a symbol of unwavering love for their children and their future.

“Life suddenly has become beautiful. I was worried that all my hair was going to turn grey from the constant worry and insecurity that came with the absence of an adequate home. I don’t have to worry about that anymore. In the new home, I feel like a king!” Vasim says, bursting into laughter with Nafisa.



A place called home, A feeling called peace

Arjun Kedari Pune, Maharashtra

With three small children, no toilet and crumbling walls, Arjun and his wife waited years for a home they could trust.

For years, Arjun Kedari and his family of five lived in a house with no toilet, no proper doors and no way to keep insects out. The floor stayed damp, flies sat on the food and the children fell sick often.

The family belongs to a nomadic Scheduled Tribe community and has lived in Thakarwadi village in Pune district of Maharashtra for generations. The old house had been around for over 30 years. Arjun was born there. After marriage, his wife, Ashwini, moved in.

“Since I got married, I have been struggling,” Ashwini says. “There was no proper place to sit or lie down. I used to get so agitated. I couldn’t rest properly, couldn’t even lie down in peace.”

She would walk to the river to relieve herself, often early in the morning or late at night. “It was always risky,” she says. “But we had no toilet. I had no choice.” Their children were often unwell. “Fever, stomach pain, skin rashes — it never stopped,” she says.

“We tried everything. We took them to doctors when we could and tried home remedies. The house was always dusty and hot. There were too many flies.”

Arjun works as a painter and also does farm labour, when there is work available. He earns between 300 rupees to 500 rupees a day. “Some days I get to work, some days I don’t,” he says. “But the house was falling apart. We were always afraid something would happen to the children.”

His wife couldn’t go to work, because she didn’t want to leave the children alone. “I used to take them along, even if they didn’t like it,” Ashwini says. “But what else could I do?”

When they were told that a new house would be built for them, she says they could barely believe it. “That’s when I started thinking about the future,” she says. “About how our children could finally grow up properly.”

Arjun helped during the construction whenever he could. “I would carry bricks, mix cement and check things with the mason,” he says. “It felt like I was helping shape something real for our children.”

The children now play indoors. One of them scribbles in a notebook on the clean floor near a solar-lit corner as the youngest sits in her mother’s lap. A small fan buzzes near the bed.

“We used to live with fear,” says Ashwini. “Now, when I look at this house, I feel calm. I feel like we have a place to grow. Like our real life is starting here.”



Homes equals a sense of belonging

Gangubai and Ramdas

Pune, Maharashtra

For years, Gangubai and her husband Ramdas lived in a small house made of mud walls, wooden sticks and a roof covered with tarpaulin. A door that barely closed offered little protection from the wind and rain. Though their home overlooked a beautiful valley, life inside was anything but serene. Each monsoon brought with it the constant fear of leaks, flooding and dampness.

Every year, the couple spent around ₹2,000 on new tarpaulin sheets to patch their roof. Without these temporary fixes, water would seep through, drenching every corner of their house. “The floor would be completely waterlogged during the monsoon,” recalls Gangubai.

The couple owned a small plot of land on which they cultivated paddy during the rainy season. But with water scarcity in the summer, they struggled to earn a steady income. Their simple dream was to have a strong home that could withstand the changing seasons.

That dream came true when Gangubai and Ramdas partnered with Habitat for Humanity India to build a safe and stable home. Like many others in their community, they rely on daily wages and agricultural labour, but today, they also have something far more lasting in the form a new home.

“We not only have a safe home, but also a hygienic toilet inside,” says Gangubai with pride. “Earlier, we used to worry about going out at night. We lost our dog to a leopard attack and were always scared after dark. Now, when we latch the door, we feel completely safe.”

For Gangubai and Ramdas, their Habitat home is the foundation for a dignified, hopeful future. With a roof that no longer leaks and walls that protect them from danger, they have finally found peace, comfort and the confidence to build a better life.



A safe home: a renewed hope for Babu's family

Babu

Yadadri Bhuvanagiri, Telangana

Babu, a domestic worker from Ramalingampally village in Yadadri Bhuvanagiri district, Telangana, lives with his wife Lavanya, a daily wage labourer, their young daughter Keerthana and his elderly mother, Maisaiah. The family had been living in a mud house that was built over 65 years ago using locally sourced wood and clay tiles.

Over the years, the structure had deteriorated severely. The house had developed deep cracks in the floor; roof leaked heavily during the rains and the doors and windows were broken. During the monsoon season, water seeped into every corner of the house and rodents, insects and even snakes frequently entered their home, turning everyday life into a constant struggle for safety, health and dignity.

With their limited income from daily labour, constructing a new home was a distant dream for the family. “Ever since the birth of our daughter Keerthana, we always aspired to build a safe and secure home,” says Babu. “But it remained just a dream.”

That long-held dream began to take shape in 2024 when Habitat for Humanity India partnered with Babu and other families in his village, working in coordination with local panchayat leaders. When he learnt that there was a possibility of building a new home, Babu was hopeful yet cautious having faced many challenges in the past. Still, he chose to take a step forward and what followed exceeded his expectations.

“It was a huge surprise, to learn that we were among the 26 other families in our village who would also have a new home. Habitat’s team consulted us while finalising the house design, explained each step of construction and treated us like family. As someone with little technical understanding of construction, I was relieved by their care and commitment. Everything was managed so smoothly, without any compromise on quality,” shares Babu.

On 21st December 2024, Babu and his family shifted to their new home. “We no longer live in fear. The safety of my daughter was my biggest concern. Now I can go to work without constantly worrying about it. We finally have peace of mind,” Babu says. “I never thought we would live in such a beautiful house,” adds Lavanya with deep gratitude.

Keerthana too feels the change in her daily life. She shares with joy, “I love to study and want to become a teacher. Now I have a beautiful home where I can do my homework and invite my friends to play and study with me. I am so happy!”



Home equals happiness

Manisha Dongre Pune, Maharashtra

Manisha (46) spent 15 years living in a rented kutchra house with her husband Vitthal, daughter Payal and son Sameer, facing daily struggles without a toilet, enduring leakages and illness. Her husband suffers from a physical disability. He worked till he could, but now he is unable to do so. For a long time, Manisha has been the only earning member of the family.

“Our daughter Payal was born many years after our marriage. When she was about 4 years old, she had high fever. It resulted in developmental disability. Among all the challenges I had to face while taking care of her, we faced a lot of discrimination from our neighbours due to my daughter’s condition. Our rented house did not have a toilet, forcing us to defecate in the open. My husband and daughter would face difficulties. They would often fall sick during the monsoon. My husband’s hand and feet would go numb often. We did not have access to water as well. As my daughter was growing up, I was always worried about her safety. I wanted to have a home where she would be safe and my entire family would be safe,” says Manisha.

She further adds, “I did not have the courage to leave my daughter and husband all by themselves. So, I had to make sure I work in places close to our house. It

was very challenging to run the house in the meagre earning that I made. We have had days when I wasn’t able to earn anything and had to rely solely on the food that our neighbours would lend us. We have even had days when we couldn’t even eat once in a day. When my son grew up, he started working as a truck driver and helped me run the house.

Habitat for Humanity India partnered with Manisha to help her build a new home. Construction began in September 2023 and in March 2024 Manisha’s family moved into their new home.

“For me, home is happiness. I feel everyone should have a home. We are very happy that this house is ours. I worked very hard on the construction of the house - from carrying stones and sand for the foundation, to watering the walls of our house. I cooked and helped the workers with everything. I faced many hurdles, but I managed to cross all of them.

“With a roof over our head, I don’t have to worry about my daughter’s safety. The safety that this home provides is the biggest relief for me.”



Fulfilling the vision of a safe home

Vikram Singh

Aakera Village, Rewari District, Haryana

Vikram Singh is a man of quiet strength, his life marked by resilience and unyielding hope. At 43, he navigates the world with a unique perspective. Despite visual impairment, his vision extends far beyond what is seen, driven by love for his family and a deep-seated determination to break free from the cycle of poverty.

Vikram shares his life with his mother, his wife Meena and their two school-going children. Together, they run a small grocery store, the primary source of income for the family. Despite his visual challenges, Vikram works tirelessly alongside his family, making sure the shop remains open and thriving. Their combined earnings cover basic necessities: food, school fees, dairy and medical expenses.

The family's living conditions are far from ideal. Their home, a two-room structure over 45 years old, struggles to withstand the test of time. During the monsoon season, water seeps through the tin roof, flooding the cramped rooms and forcing them to move their belongings constantly to keep them dry. Yet, the physical state of the house is just one of their many challenges.

"We don't have a bathroom or toilet," Vikram shared. "We have to rely on neighbours or go far into the fields to relieve ourselves." For Vikram, whose vision makes navigating unfamiliar spaces daunting, this lack of basic sanitation is a daily struggle.

The weight of responsibility grew heavier after the loss of his father last year. "My father was the main provider. His death has put a lot of financial pressure on me," Vikram shared, his voice a mix of resignation and hope. Even with the mounting challenges, his spirit remained unbroken.

On 19th November 2025, as he stood before his new home, a sense of disbelief and gratitude filled his heart. "I am so grateful for this opportunity. This new home will change our lives. It will be a place where my children can grow up safe and healthy," Vikram said, his voice brimming with emotion.

The new house is more than just four walls and a roof; it is a promise of dignity and security. Designed with Vikram's visual impairment in mind, the home structure features a levelled floor wide doorways and sanitation units that make it easier for him to navigate independently.

For the first time, the family has a proper kitchen, a clean bathroom, an ample amount of natural lighting and enough space for everyone to rest comfortably.

"I can now move around freely without the fear of tripping or bumping into things," Vikram shared, his relief evident. His wife, Meena, echoed his sentiments. "We can now cook and clean comfortably. The children have their own room and we have a space to relax and spend time together." For them, the house represents not just physical security, but a chance to dream bigger — to imagine a life unbounded by the constraints of poverty and fragile walls.

Vikram's story is a testament to the power of safe and accessible housing. His journey underscores how strong, stable homes are crucial for building resilient communities, especially for individuals living with disabilities.



Ram Dei's new home brings new hope

Ram Dei

Aakera village, Rewari district, Haryana

In Aakera, Haryana, a family once bound by hardship now embraces a new chapter of hope. For years, Komal (22) and Manish (20) faced the harsh realities of life, shouldering burdens far beyond their years. Childhood games and dreams were swapped for the harsh responsibility of family care. Along with their mother, Ram Dei, they faced each day with courage, striving to overcome financial hardship and the challenges of living in inadequate housing.

Thirteen years ago, tragedy struck when Ram Dei's husband, Shamsher, passed away. From that moment, the family's struggles multiplied.

"It was a tough time," Manish recalled. "I had to balance work and studies, but the financial burden forced me to choose earning a living. It was heartbreaking to leave school, but I had to support my family," he adds. Komal shared her own sacrifices, saying, "I had to give up my education to take care of my mother and the household. It was difficult, but it was necessary."

Their home, a single dilapidated room, lacked basic amenities and suffered from severe water-logging during monsoons. "We had no privacy, no security. The condition of the house was always a source of stress," Komal explained. But this relentless cycle of hardship was about to change.

In 2024, their lives were transformed when Habitat for Humanity India, helped them build a new home. This partnership was a lifeline for the family. The

safe, secure home equipped with a living room, bedroom, kitchen, toilet and bathroom became their gateway to a better future.

"It feels like a dream," Manish says with a mixture of disbelief and joy. "We never thought we would own a home like this. It's a new reality now. I am excited to have my own room, where I can relax and study."

"Our old home was making us sick," Komal shares. "Before, every rupee we earned went towards fixing the roof, replacing broken windows, or dealing with the constant fear of flooding. It was a never-ending cycle. The dampness, the mould — it always affected our health. Now, with proper ventilation and a healthy living environment, we feel so much better. We have more money to save and invest in our future. My brother can focus on his work without the constant worry about our living conditions. And I can finally think about starting my own small business," Komal adds.

The spacious home has brought them the privacy they longed for, with each member of the family now able to enjoy their own space. The family is no longer trapped in a cycle of poverty. Their new home is not just a physical shelter, but a foundation for a brighter future. The once constant struggles of survival are now replaced by moments of joy.



Turning dreams into solar-powered reality

Sumitra Lohar

Paschim Midnapore, West Bengal

“Having a proper home with electricity, a kitchen, and a toilet was my dream. But with the little we earned working in the brick factory, it always felt out of reach,” says Sumitra Lohar (46) from Sarenga village, Paschim Midnapore, West Bengal.

Sumitra lives with her husband Nirananda (49), son Shibnath (22), daughter-in-law Rupsa (20), and one-year-old granddaughter Sonia. Until recently, the family lived in a small house made of mud walls and a thatched roof. Rainwater would seep in during monsoon, and the summer heat turned the home into an oven.

With a combined monthly income of just ₹8,000 from daily wage labour, improving their living conditions seemed impossible.

“During summer we had no electricity, so we would sit under trees or fan ourselves to stay cool,” recalls Sumitra.

That changed when the family moved into their new home built in partnership Habitat for Humanity India.

The Lohar family’s new home features solid walls, a veranda-cum-kitchen, a toilet, and a rooftop solar system that powers two lights and a fan. Families were also trained to maintain their solar units, enabling them to embrace renewable energy and build resilience against climate challenges.

“Now I can cook delicious meals for my family with ease. This has been my dream for so long,” says Sumitra with pride. “We no longer have to search for secluded spots to relieve ourselves.”

For her son, the fan and lights powered by solar energy are a blessing. “There are constant power failures in our area, but now we have uninterrupted power at home,” says Shibnath.

Sumitra smiles as she watches her granddaughter sleep peacefully. “Sonia sleeps better with the fan. It gives her so much relief and comfort.”

What once felt like an impossible dream is now a reality — a home filled with light, safety and dignity.



Building a home to thrive and grow

Motiram Waghmare

Wada village, Khed block, Pune district, Maharashtra

“We are a family of 6 and used to live in a small hut. We could barely sleep and had very little space to do our household work. In the rainy season, it was difficult for all of us to live in that small shack which hardly qualified as a home.” – Motiram.

If he hadn’t partnered with Habitat for Humanity India, Motiram and his family would still live in a small, run-down, mud- walled house in Wada village, located in Khed block of Pune district in Maharashtra. The mud walls and thatched roof offered little protection to the family especially during the unforgiving monsoon season.

“During heavy rains, water used to seep into the house, causing many problems. The kids would fall sick frequently. The entire family’s security was at stake. We had one metal suitcase in which we kept important documents such as the ration card, Aadhaar cards, etc. That suitcase protected our identity all these years,” Motiram continues.

A fisherman by profession, Motiram’s daily struggles were compounded by the declining yields from the nearby river, where he cast his nets in hopes of a decent catch. The absence of basic amenities like electricity, toilet and bathroom made life even more challenging especially for his wife and young children. Daily expenses ate away his earnings while the cost of medical bills made savings impossible.

Motiram and his family’s dreams of a better life and a habitable home seemed improbable. But partnering with Habitat for Humanity India proved to be instrumental.

In 2023, Habitat for Humanity India undertook an innovative project to build climate-resilient homes, an effort to build homes sustainably amidst the rising challenges of climate change. The homes are designed in a unique way and consist of a living room, kitchen, bedroom, bathroom and a toilet. The climate-resilient features of each home include natural ventilation, natural light, solar rooftop, rainwater harvesting, greywater treatment and a vegetable garden.

After conducting a baseline assessment, Habitat India shortlisted 15 marginalised families belonging to the Katkari tribe who were living in poor housing conditions. Motiram is one of the 15 homeowners. He also participated in the construction process pouring his sweat and determination into every brick and beam.

“My children used to study under candlelight. Now, with proper lights, studying is easier for them. We are very happy to see their improvement. Also, they won’t get sick as much anymore,” he further adds.

His new home stands as a symbol of resilience and progress. Equipped with solar energy and rainwater harvesting facilities, it offers a ray of light amidst the darkness of their previous struggles. With uninterrupted power supply, his children can now study even at night, making cooking and other household chores easier too. The bathroom and sanitation unit brings a newfound sense of dignity and convenience to his family’s daily lives. Motiram’s journey from hardship to hope is a testament to the transformative power of housing. A brighter future now seems within reach.

“Our new home is a source of unending happiness and pride for me. My children love this house. My wife is not worried about my children’s safety anymore. Now, we can finally embrace a future filled with promise and possibility.”

For Motiram’s family, the new home represents more than just shelter – it’s a place to thrive and grow.

The climate resilient housing project has its genesis in the 4th edition of charity golf tournament organised by Habitat for Humanity India on 4th February 2023. The cause for the tournament was building climate resilient homes. Ashish Kacholia (Investor), D. C. Patel (Managing Director, Laxmi Board and Paper Mills Pvt. Ltd) and R. Gopal (Managing Director, Goodrich Maritime Pvt. Ltd.) have supported this project enabling Habitat India built 15 homes which are equipped with solar energy and rainwater harvesting facilities.



Sustainability in homes and lives

Susama Das

Bhubaneswar, Odisha

Simanchal Das stands at the door of his new home with his wife Susama. Together, they look at the narrow street that used to flood every monsoon, filling their old hut with water. The couple, both in their fifties work as daily-wage labourers and live with their youngest of the three daughters. “Every time it rained, we were scared that our house would break,” says Simanchal.

“My earliest memory of entering this house is as a bride and I remember the roof being so low, I had to bend to get inside the house,” shares Susama. Their old house was made of mud, clay and scrap tin. The cracked walls let in wind. Rainwater came in easily and turned the mud floor soft and slippery. “We had to move our bedding and utensils again and again,” says Susama.

Sometimes snakes entered through the broken walls. There was no toilet inside the house, so they had to go outside even at night or in the rain.

Simanchal often walked long distances to find work at construction sites. He earned ₹500 - ₹600 a day. It was just enough to buy food. They could not afford to repair their house. Over time, Simanchal’s eyesight and hearing became weak. This made it harder for him to get work. “If we missed even one day of work, we had no food,” says Susama.

At a time when repairs seemed impossible, three vulnerable families including Susama’s family were supported by Habitat for Humanity India to build climate-resilient homes that were not only safe and strong but also sustainable.

During the selection process, Simanchal remembers sharing his concerns with the Habitat India team. “We told them that if a proper home is built, we will never have to worry about the water entering our homes or sleeping on wet floors. That is all. I was very happy when we were selected. It feels like it was Lord Jagannath’s blessing,” Simanchal shares.

The house has plinths to avoid flooding, solar panels for clean energy and a proper kitchen to cook without smoke filling the room. “We feel safe and secure in every season. The worry is gone,” she says. “When we were first told that a new home would be built for us, it was hard to believe,” Susama shares. “Even our neighbours were skeptical and wondered if it could really happen for people like us. Today, our dream has come true. There are many families in our neighbourhood who still need safe housing. I hope Habitat for Humanity will one day help them too.”

The home also includes rainwater harvesting, thermal insulation and systems to manage water and waste efficiently, all part of a thoughtful design that keeps the family comfortable and reduces the environmental impact of the home. The new house is also equipped with a sanitation unit.

The street outside still floods sometimes, but the Das family is no longer afraid. From their doorstep, they watch the rain without worry. “Earlier, one big storm could destroy everything. Now when it rains, we sleep peacefully knowing the walls will hold,” says Simanchal.

The project introduced green construction technologies to build safe, sustainable homes for families vulnerable to floods and climate risks.

Each home includes features such as raised plinths to protect against flooding, solar panels for clean, reliable energy, rainwater harvesting systems, water and waste management solutions and thermal insulation for comfort in all seasons. All three homes have been awarded the ‘NEST GOLD’ (IGBC NEST) rating by Indian Green Building Council, recognising Habitat for Humanity’s commitment to sustainable, affordable and climate-resilient housing.

These certified homes now stand as model examples of green housing at the individual household level. They demonstrate that sustainability is achievable even in small-scale, affordable housing projects, paving the way for the wider adoption of green building practices among vulnerable communities in Odisha and beyond.



A step toward health and dignity

Mina

Wada, Maharashtra

Mina, an ASHA (Accredited Social Health Activist) worker since 2009, has been supporting households in Wada, a village in Khed block of Maharashtra. Over the years, she has witnessed numerous health issues, including diarrhoea, caused by open defecation.

“Health problems peak during the monsoons. Mosquitoes and other bugs expose us to several infections,” Mina shared. When villagers suffered from diarrhoea, the situation worsened because they had to visit open defecation spots multiple times a day. Inadequate household sanitation compromises the health and well-being of entire communities. “Women and girls are particularly vulnerable to infections throughout the year,” Mina added. “Having toilets will reduce medical expenses, protect families from diseases and help them feel safer.” She expressed relief that the toilets were built before the monsoons and ready for use.

Despite being an ASHA worker, Mina and her family did not have a toilet of their own. She had to walk at least 15 minutes to reach the open defecation spot, making the trip at least twice daily for her family, which includes her husband and son.

Mina was relieved that a toilet could be constructed at her doorstep. “We are very grateful that we managed to build it. I never imagined it could be completed so quickly. It’s fantastic!” she exclaims.

The project followed an owner-driven construction model, involving families, local masons and the Gram Panchayat. This model encourages community participation, fosters ownership and promotes behavioural change. Most importantly, it engages families in the decision-making process and empowers them.



A toilet for every child

Sri Shingeshwar Vidyalaya

Pune, Maharashtra

For these schoolchildren, sanitation has finally caught up with learning.

The students of Sri Shingeshwar Vidyalaya, Kude, used to line up behind a stand of thorny shrubs behind the science block. The ground was uneven and full of loose stones. When it rained, the path became a stream of red mud. There were no walls, no door and no tap to wash their hands. Many boys laughed it off, calling it “outside practice,” but the girls often waited until the last bell, walking home with aching stomachs.

“Once it rained so hard, I could not see the field,” says Neha of Grade 9. “I held it all day. By evening I felt dizzy and my stomach hurt. The next morning, the teacher sent me to the clinic.” Neha missed two days of lessons that week.

Others began skipping school during their periods. The old sanitation shed had cracked floors and a broken roof. After a while even the teachers stopped unlocking it.

Open defecation was risky for the boys as well. “It was embarrassing to run behind the bushes,” says Om from Grade 10. “We were always scared of snakes. One time a friend jumped and fell because he saw something move in the grass. It felt like a game, who could finish fastest and run back. Now we have real toilets. Life is easier.”

The turning point came when Habitat for Humanity India partnered with the school located in Khed block of Pune district in Maharashtra to build a new sanitation unit. Workers dug a solid foundation beside the classroom wing, laid iron reinforced walls and fixed separate entrances for girls and boys. Inside

there are two stalls for girls, two for boys, a handwashing sink with running water and tiled floors that can be cleaned each day. Outside, a small ramp makes the block usable for students with injuries or disabilities.

Attendance records show the change. In the month before the new block opened, seven girls missed at least three days each. Last month only one girl missed class and she returned the next morning. “I do not have to ask for early leave during my period now,” adds Neha, smiling at the fresh paint on the door. “I feel normal, like the boys. I can stay for the full timetable.”

Teachers notice stronger focus in class. Students wash their hands with soap after using the toilet and before midday snacks. The smell that once drifted through the back windows is gone. “It is a small building, but it changed the mood of the whole school,” says Kailas, School leader, sitting at his desk with the attendance register open. “A clean, safe toilet is not a luxury. It is a child’s right.”

Parents, too, have begun to talk. Some mothers who once kept their daughters at home during menstruation now let them attend every day. Boys stay on the playground longer because they do not need to run home after lunch. With forty-five students, the school is small, but the new block shows what a firm wall and a working tap can do.

Each morning, a few students help clean the toilets and make sure there’s soap and water by the hand washing area. “I used to feel ashamed,” says Neha, rinsing her hands before heading home. “Now I feel safe.”



Restoring dignity and safety for Irula tribal families

Habitat for Humanity India's journey with the Irula tribal community began in the aftermath of the 2015 Tamil Nadu floods, when our disaster response teams witnessed first hand the poor, marginalised and vulnerable living conditions faced by Irula families. What began as an immediate humanitarian intervention evolved into a long-term partnership built on trust, collaboration and shared aspirations for dignity and inclusion.

Recognising that secure land tenure and adequate housing are key to breaking the cycle of poverty, Habitat India initiated sustained engagement with the Irula community under the Solid Ground Campaign from 2016-2020. This initiative focused on facilitating access to land title, housing and basic services — while working in close coordination with local communities, grassroots organisations and government departments at the district and state levels.

Over the years, this partnership has grown into a model of collective action. Through continued dialogue with public institutions and the empowerment of community-based organisations, hundreds of Irula families have been able to obtain land titles, access government welfare schemes and move into homes of their own for the first time. Today, several Irula men and women are participating in local governance and leading community development efforts, reflecting a powerful shift from marginalisation to self-determination.

This sustained journey is not just about building homes — it is about building resilience and aspirations of one of India's oldest indigenous communities. The progress achieved so far demonstrates what can be accomplished when communities, government and civil society come together with a shared vision of inclusive growth.





Home equals dignity

Transformation beyond bricks and mortar

Tiruvallur, Tamil Nadu

In Senjiyamman Nagar, Tiruvallur district, **Ramya** stands at the doorway of her repaired home, holding her newborn child while her two older children play nearby. For the first time in years, she feels at ease.

“Our community depends on fishing. Both my husband and I work just to meet our daily needs. In that situation, repairing our home was impossible,” she recalls. “We didn’t have a bathroom. I had to leave my children with my grandmother whenever I went outside. On days she went to work, I held it in the whole day.”

Life inside the house was no easier. “When I gave birth to my elder son, insects and even snakes would crawl in. Rainwater leaked through the roof and I often feared it might collapse on us. Now, with a repaired home and a toilet next to it, I no longer worry about the rain or about leaving my children at home. Earlier it felt like we were living in a rented house. Now, my children ask me, ‘It feels like a new home. Will it stay like this?’ And I tell them, ‘If we keep it clean, it will remain the same.’”

Ramya is one of 49 Irula tribal families in Tiruvallur district who partnered with Habitat for Humanity India to repair their homes and build new sanitation units. The project improved the living conditions of 245 people from these 49 households.

For **Ramesh**, the village leader of Senjiyamman Nagar, the transformation went beyond bricks and mortar. “Dignity and respect matter to everyone. Sadly, as members of the Irula tribal community, we have rarely been treated with such consideration. Earlier, when repairs were needed in our homes, the workers we hired often demanded that we step outside while they work, making us feel like outsiders in our own spaces. But this time, it was different. From labourers to the entire Habitat for Humanity India team, everyone treated us with dignity and respect. Even the construction workers sought our permission before entering our homes. For the first time in our lives, we truly felt seen, valued and respected.”

For **Murugesan** and his wife Kokila, the change was life-altering. Living with a visual impairment and the stigma of leprosy, Murugesan had spent years inside his old, crumbling home. “We never stepped out,” Kokila remembers. “But after our new house was built, we went out for the first time to attend the handover ceremony. That day, we felt like we could finally introduce ourselves to the others. It felt like a new beginning.” Their earlier home offered little protection from rain and sanitation was a daily challenge. The bathrooms were makeshift bathrooms — just sticks covered with sarees. “Now we have a proper bathroom. We don’t need to go outside. Our basic needs are met and we feel confident and truly content,” says Murugesan.

For the Irula families, these improved homes represent restored dignity and renewed hope for generations to come.

Building Strength for Farmers' widows

India is widely known for its lush fields of rice, tea and coffee plantations and a wide variety of forests and landscapes that make up the varied patchwork of the country's agriculture. It is an agrarian country with almost 70% of its population depending either directly or indirectly on agriculture.

In this scene of agricultural diversity sits a staggering statistic concerning the men who till the country's land. Over the years, many farmers across India died by suicide, leaving thousands of families — wives and children — struggling to claim their right to the land they till and the house they live in.

In rural areas especially, widows in India are highly stigmatised, subjected to abuse, kicked out of their homes, denied food and blamed for the deaths of their husbands. For many women who attempt to continue farming, hiring and managing male labourers, traders and other farmers

becomes a real challenge. Although the issue of farmer suicide garners attention across India, their widows live every day in the shadow of their husbands' deaths, often with little to no attention.

In the midst of these struggles are often young children who need quality education that will give them a chance to live better lives. A home provides women with the shelter they need to raise their children — a home that gives them dignity and respect in society and a safe place to protect their family within.

Habitat for Humanity India partners with the widows of farmers to build homes for them and their families. Between 2016 and 2018, Habitat India focused on building homes across the state of Maharashtra, building strength through shelter for these women.



Mannabi Shaikh

Dharashiv, Maharashtra

Ridden with debt and extreme stress, Mannabi's husband decided to end his life. Distraught and forsaken, Mannabi was left to fend for her little children - a daughter and two sons. Since then, she has struggled to make a living for her family. She worked as a labourer and raised her children singlehandedly.

Through all her trials and tribulations, Mannabi and her family lived in a dilapidated house. Habitat for Humanity India partnered with Mannabi and supported her in constructing a safe, permanent home for her family.

When asked what her new home has given her, Mannabi responds instantaneously "Sukoon," meaning peace. The home is a matter of pride for Mannabi as she runs a tailoring business in the house with her sewing machine. It has given her family stability and an opportunity to build a better future. A Habitat home does not only provide a roof over a family but also becomes a reason for joy and stability for the individuals living in it.



A story of strength and resilience

Vidya More

Jhanshi Chi Rani Women's Self-Help Group
Dharashiv, Maharashtra

Vidya was married to Sahadev at a young age. She has two children - Ganesh and Vaishnavi. To make ends meet, Sahadev juggled two demanding roles as a farmer and a driver. However, it was difficult for him to make enough for his family and the pressures of responsibilities led him to fall prey to alcohol. He eventually had to quit his job as a driver, leaving the family to rely on his meagre earnings from farming. Financial difficulties forced him to accumulate a substantial debt, pushing the family to borrow money for basic necessities. In a moment of despair, Sahadev decided to end his life thinking that this would bring an end to all his problems. He set himself on fire and moved towards his family to grab them. Vidya, shocked and scared, ran out of the house with her children and escaped. Sahadev, succumbing to his burns, left Vidya alone to cope with the loan and care for her children.

Initially devastated, Vidya faced the daunting challenge of survival and repaying the debt. "He chose death. I didn't want my kids to face the same fate," Vidya said on the heartbreaking circumstances. She learnt to farm the land which her husband had left behind after his death. She also took on tailoring jobs to support the family and by working overtime, she was finally able to repay the entire loan. Then she set out on a mission to build a proper home for her children.

Due to the challenging financial circumstances and the loss of their previous home in the devastating fire, Vidya and her children had relocated to a kutchra house constructed from tin sheets. When Habitat for Humanity India initiated its efforts to build homes in Sarola village for widows of farmers, Vidya was selected as one of the homeowners.

"My children had to keep going to the neighbour's house to study because of the lack of electricity. But they could not sit there for long and had to keep cutting their study time short. When we were finally able to build this home,

my daughter was in Class 10 and Ganesh was in Class 12. The children were extremely happy when we moved into our new home and were even more delighted to learn that they now have electricity in the new home," she adds.

With a roof over her head, Vidya turned to empowering other women in her village. She founded the Jhanshi Chi Rani Women's Self-Help Group (SHG). After the COVID-19 pandemic, Habitat India helped Vidya and members of her SHG set up a dal mill enabling them to improve their standard of living. "We came together and started running the mill. Today, we make good profit and have even been able to purchase an atta mill to expand the enterprise," she says. "We have come a long way. Everything started with a home. It has given us a new lease of life," she added.

With guidance from Habitat, they purchased and installed a dal machine. "We built a shed with SHG funds and handled everything ourselves," Vidya proudly shares. They cultivated lentils on their small farms, processed them at the mill and sold the dal to local shopkeepers.

"For years, society labelled us as bad omens. We were excluded from ceremonies, but now we are treated with respect. Habitat didn't just provide us with support; they restored our dignity. Today, we make good profits and have even been able to purchase an atta mill to expand our enterprise," says Vidya. Vidya's resilience has transformed not only her life but also those of the women around her. Her son has now completed his diploma in agriculture and the family has come a long way from the struggles of the past. "Recently, my son got married. It was a moment of immense pride for me, knowing how far we have come," she beams.

"Together, we have proven that no matter how deep the darkness is, there is always a way to light," she says, embodying the spirit of true leadership.



Housing Disaster Resilience and **RESPONSE**

Every year, natural disasters displace millions of people across India from their homes.

Through Habitat's Housing Disaster Resilience and Response programme and with the help of volunteers and donors like you, we are able to provide shelter assistance, education, training and partnerships to the affected individuals who find themselves in unthinkable situations.

When a disaster strikes, the loss of a home can leave you at your most vulnerable. Habitat works to rebuild communities in these circumstances, moving them from ruin to recovery.

The most basic needs become both scarce and dire in the event of an emergency: health, water, shelter, sanitation, livelihoods, safety and education, among

others. We believe that safe, reliable shelter provides the foundation from which all of these things can begin to reemerge during the relief and rebuilding process.

Therefore, within our HDRR we have instituted the Pathways to Permanence strategy. It is the process of reducing vulnerability and supporting disaster-affected families and communities using holistic program interventions that enable incremental progress toward the achievement of permanent, durable shelter and settlements. This allows us to guide individuals and families through the necessary steps in taking back more control of their living situation following a natural disaster.

Interventions that support the process may include, but are not limited to, emergency shelter kits, transitional shelter, home repairs, disaster resilient homes and community-based disaster risk mitigation training.



Her name is Sakthi, her spirit is strength

Sakthi

Villupuram, Tamil Nadu

Sakthi, lives in Vembi village located in Villupuram district of Tamil Nadu with her two children, Sanjay and Hemavathi. Three years ago, her husband Murugan was fatally struck by lightning while herding cattle, leaving Sakthi to navigate life as a widow. The recurring floods in her neighbourhood have only intensified her struggles, as each monsoon brings the same devastating consequences — her house gets waterlogged and the floors remain soaked for weeks, causing significant damage.

“Every time it rains, our house gets flooded,” Sakthi explains. “We use utensils to collect the water and pour it outside, but the water keeps coming in. The fields get flooded too leaving us without work during these times, which makes it even harder to provide for my children.”

When Cyclone Fengal triggered severe floods across the coastal belt of Tamil Nadu in December 2024, Sakthi sent Sanjay and Hemavathi to a relative’s house for safety while she stayed behind to protect their home. “It took me two weeks, using jute bags and mugs, to drain the water from our home,” shares Sakthi. Despite her best efforts, the flooding and damage left her exhausted. “I cleaned the house alone, staying inside while the water was still on the ground. My children were safe, but I could not prevent the devastation,” she further adds.

Sakthi earns around 150 to 200 rupees per day through agricultural labour and odd jobs. “Whatever little I earn is not enough to cover all our expenses,” she shares. Through Habitat for Humanity India’s Housing Disaster Resilience and

Response (HDRR) programme, Emergency Shelter Kits (ESKs) were provided to 1,206 families like Sakthi’s who were impacted by Cyclone

Fengal. The kits were distributed to the families belonging to the Irula tribe and other marginalised communities residing in Koliyanur, Vikravandi, Thiruvennai Nallur, Kandamangalam and Kanai blocks of Villupuram district. Designed to offer immediate relief, the ESKs help families build temporary shelters or carry out basic repairs to their damaged homes, creating safe spaces until more permanent solutions can be put in place.

Each kit consists of a tarpaulin sheet, rope, nails, a claw hammer, tie wire, a plier, a hoe, handle and a covering sheet. Habitat for Humanity India follows a ‘Pathways to Permanence’ approach of responding to disasters in a phased manner beginning with immediate relief in the form of emergency shelter kits, followed by home repairs or transitional shelters and ultimately supporting families to build disaster-resilient permanent homes.

“The tarpaulin sheets were a huge help. They kept us dry,” Sakthi says. “The tools were useful to carry out repairs and to make our house a little stronger. Without this support, we would have been completely overwhelmed.” While the Emergency Shelter Kit has made a noticeable difference, Sakthi remains deeply concerned about the future. “Every time it rains, I get scared that our house will get flooded again in future. I am doing my best but I cannot afford to build a permanent home on my own. My daily wage is only enough to cover our food and basic needs. All I want is a safe home for my children.”

Sakthi’s resilience in the face of loss and hardship is a powerful reminder of the strength mothers carry even when they have so little. Despite the odds, she continues to fight for a better future for her children.



Rediscovering pathways to resilience and brighter days

Ujala

Barpeta, Assam

Ujala, 52, lives in Shalekura village with her husband and their son. Her husband, Abdul, worked in brick kilns for over 14 years, but three years ago, he lost his vision in an accident while harvesting. Since then, Ujala has taken on the responsibility of supporting the family as a daily wage labourer, though finding regular work has been difficult. As a result, their son, Fulchan, had to drop out of college and migrate for work.

Back in the day, Ujala and Abdul worked in multiple brick kilns across Assam, often leaving their children behind so they could attend school. During the off-season, Abdul took up daily wage labour in nearby villages. “We worked hard, hoping to build a better future,” Ujala says. “But despite our efforts, life turned out differently.”

The family lives in a flood-prone area where yearly floods disrupt their lives. Roads, rice fields and homes, including theirs, are submerged. When floodwater rises inside their home, they elevate their beds and take shelter on them. “We have no way to communicate or move around. We depend on other people’s country boats (small boats used for local water transport) just to reach the market,” Ujala explained.

The floods cause enormous hardship for Ujala’s family. Floods mean lost wages. Additionally, they are unable to adequately prepare for the floods due to financial constraints. “We don’t have any work during the floods, so we have to sell our poultry just to make ends meet,” Ujala recounts.

In a desperate attempt to improve their situation, the family leased a small plot of land to grow rice. However, last year’s flood ruined their crops thrice, leaving them with nothing to save for the year. Their situation became increasingly perilous with each passing flood, intensifying their grief.

Habitat for Humanity India provided an Emergency Shelter Kit (ESK) to Ujala’s family. With the spade, Ujala has found work in earth-moving jobs, while the tarpaulin protects their bed from cold and dampness in winter.

Using the rope, she has also created a guide path for Abdul to reach the toilet safely. “These items have been extremely useful. We could not afford them on our own. Earlier, we had to borrow them from others during emergencies,” says Ujala.

While challenges remain, the support has provided Ujala’s family with comfort, dignity and hope. The tools from the ESK will help them prepare for future hardships, ensuring they are better equipped to face the next crisis. As part of its Disaster Risk Reduction initiative, Habitat for Humanity India, has provided Emergency Shelter Kits to 329 families affected by Cyclone Remal in Dhubri and Barpeta districts of Assam. Each ESK consists of a tarpaulin sheet, covering sheet, hammer, spade, nails and washers, tie wire, rope, handsaw and a plier, helping them rebuild their homes and livelihoods.



Home as a shelter for arts and traditions

Rasmati

Dhubri, Assam

Forty-year-old Rasmati, a potter, lives in Khorida village in Assam's Dhubri district with her husband Nikhil, three children, daughter-in-law and grandchildren. She belongs to the Pal community, which has traditionally earned a living through pottery. However, the Pal community is also one of the most marginalised in the region and pottery is no longer a profitable trade.

With dwindling demand, many families have been forced to take up daily wage labour to survive. Nikhil was once a skilled potter but now works as a labourer in the locality. Their two sons assist in Dashakarma shops (stores that sell goods for religious ceremonies) in Bihar, but they are not yet financially stable enough to support the family.

Determined to sustain her family, Rasmati continues pottery — her lifelong skill and passion. “My ancestors made pottery and I learned from them. I want to carry forward this tradition, even if it does not bring in much income. Pottery is a tough craft that involves many challenges. We have to source suitable soil from other places, prepare the clay and shape the pots. Once ready, we must protect them from water before firing them in the kiln,” she explains. The lack of proper storage for raw pottery has led to significant losses, especially

during the monsoon. Frequent floods, exacerbated by an elevated railway line that prevents water from draining out, submerge Rasmati's home and damage her unfinished pottery.

In the aftermath of Cyclone Remal that devastated the lives of people, Rasmati felt a sense of relief when Habitat for Humanity India provided her with an Emergency Shelter Kit (ESK). The kit contained essential materials that have made a tangible difference in her daily life.

“The tarpaulin sheets help me protect the raw pottery from rain and dew,” she shares. “The spade is one of the most important tools for my craft. It makes it easier to dig soil and mix clay. I am less worried now. I have even made a makeshift shade to keep my products safe.”

This small yet significant intervention has given Rasmati a better chance of securing her livelihood, even in the face of recurring floods. It has also helped preserve a centuries-old craft that is an integral part of her community's heritage.



Volunteer Programme

Every year, business leaders, corporate professionals and students from India and around the world come together to build alongside families and help them fulfil their lifelong dream of having a decent home. The volunteers make a real difference. They connect with the families, immerse themselves in new cultures and learn about Habitat's mission. They raise awareness and advocate for improved housing and quality of life. With the support from volunteers, families can achieve the strength, stability and independence they need to build a better life.



Legacy Builds

In March 2024 and 2025, two transformative Volunteer Builds took place in Nashik, Maharashtra and Bengaluru, Karnataka. Together, more than 40 volunteers partnered with six tribal families to help build safe, permanent homes.

The builds were co-led by Anthony Miller, a long-time Habitat volunteer and member of Habitat for Humanity's Asia-Pacific Development Council and Cecilia Melin, Executive Director of Habitat for Humanity Japan. They were joined by students from Habitat Japan's campus chapters, who travelled to India to contribute their energy and enthusiasm.

The first build in Nashik, Maharashtra, saw volunteers work alongside three families, learning first-hand about the housing challenges they face. "Our group built a home for a mom, a dad and their three young kids. Before seeing it in person, I could not have imagined what the mud house where they lived was like. I realised how hard it must be to study, work and raise those three young children in these conditions. It made me think about just how many people around the world need a decent place to live, with Japan as no exception," shared Utana Arai, a student volunteer.

A year later, in March 2025, the second build took place in the Hakki-Pikki colony in Anekal, Bengaluru. Here, volunteers partnered with three more families belonging to the marginalised Hakki Pikki community. Among them was Parani, a

grandmother who shared, "My family is looking forward to our new home, but the most excited is my granddaughter, who is expecting a baby. She will raise her child in a safe and secure home."

For Anthony Miller, who has volunteered in 17 builds globally, including three in India, the experience was deeply personal. "Each build is a powerful reminder of the impact a home can have on a family. Housing transforms lives by providing security and stability and a Habitat build gives us an opportunity to witness that transformation firsthand. I am glad we could help families move closer to their dream of having a home of their own and I am especially happy that my daughter could be a part of this experience." The first Legacy Build led by Mr. Miller and Ms. Melin took place in Karjat, Raigad district, Maharashtra in 2020.

"The most wonderful thing about a Volunteer Build like this is that you go out with a group of people and are in turn able to make a difference in their lives." – Cecilia Melin, Executive Director, Habitat for Humanity Japan.

In 2025, a total of 149 participants including corporate professionals, students and youth volunteered with Habitat for Humanity India. Till date, Habitat India's Volunteer Build Programme has engaged 56,388 volunteers, enabling them to work shoulder to shoulder with families, address housing needs and contribute to sustainable housing solutions across the country.



Kamma, Somya and Kanyashree

Habitat Homeowners

Hakki Pikki Community, Anekal, Bengaluru, Karnataka

“In our old house, when it rained heavily, water would pour in because the roof was broken,” says Somya, a young woman from the Hakki Pikki tribal community in Anekal, Bengaluru. “Even to use the toilet, we had to go into the forest. It was especially hard for my grandfather, who has trouble walking.”

For generations, the Hakki Pikki — meaning bird catchers — have lived on the margins, often in unsafe and inadequate housing. Many families had to manage without toilets, proper doors or protection from the rain. These conditions were especially difficult for women, children and the elderly.

Kamma, a daily wage labourer, recalls the challenges her family faced. “Our old house did not have a door. Cows would enter and eat the rice and ration items. When we tried to stop them, people argued and fought with us,” she says.

For Kanyashree and her sisters, the absence of sanitation facilities made life even harder. “We somehow managed to relieve ourselves outside, but it was challenging for the elderly, especially for my mother. During the rainy season, she slipped on the rocks and fell. Now, she is unwell.”

This year brought a turning point for the community. Habitat for Humanity India partnered with three Hakki Pikki families in Anekal to build safe, permanent homes. The effort was part of the Legacy Build

— a five-day initiative that brought together international volunteers, global corporate leaders and the families themselves to work side by side.

The student volunteers from Japan found the experience deeply meaningful. “I was able to have such a happy and joyful time that I did not even notice the things that I thought were difficult,” says Kanai from Nihon University. “I think I gained a lot more than I gave,” adds Sashihara from the University of Tokyo.

For Magda, the Build held an even deeper significance. “Anything you can do to help other women means so much. It means a lot to provide everyone with a safe living situation. I really believe in Habitat’s mission,” she reflects.

As the houses neared completion, hope began to fill the hearts of the Hakki Pikki families. “Supported by a new house specially constructed by volunteers from outside the country makes us feel very happy,” says Somya with a smile. “Having this house built for us brings great joy to me,” adds Kamma.

Today, the Hakki Pikki families in Anekal no longer worry about leaking roofs or unsafe nights. They have a secure place to call home - a space filled with dignity, laughter and the promise of a better tomorrow. Their new homes stand as symbols of resilience and of what becomes possible when communities and volunteers come together through compassion and shared purpose.

Muskan – From Young Volunteer to Global Changemaker

Muskan’s journey with Habitat for Humanity India began in 2016, when she was just 13 years old. Her first volunteering experience was during the Jacqueline Builds campaign led by actress Jacqueline Fernandez, which supported families affected by natural disasters in Kerala and Tamil Nadu. The following year, she attended the Habitat Young Leaders Build Conference in partnership with the Centre for Creative Leadership in Mumbai as the youngest participant in a room full of adults — an experience that ignited her lifelong commitment to community service and leadership.

Over the past decade, Muskan has grown from a passionate student volunteer to a confident 23-year-old youth leader and social changemaker. Her work with Habitat India has evolved into a platform for advocacy, innovation and empowerment, especially for women in vulnerable communities.

In 2025, Muskan’s efforts were recognised on a global stage when she received a \$4,000 Habitat Youth Solutions Grant at the Habitat Youth Assembly, a global platform that celebrates innovative housing solutions by young leaders. Her project, Chhat Shakti, addresses the impact of extreme heat in low-income homes in Karjat, Maharashtra, by applying solar reflective roof coatings to cool homes naturally while also training women to apply the coating, enabling them to earn an income and take charge of climate resilience in their communities.



Muskan Lund

Habitat Volunteer

Habitat has been one of the greatest blessings in my life. Not because of recognition or visibility, but because it has taught me the value of service. It has pushed me to do better, to feel deeply, to grow as a human being. When you are doing something that feels so aligned with your purpose, when your work brings you joy and peace, that is when you know you are truly home.



Dream Harbour

Digital Artist :

Samiksha Somani

Softwares Used :

Adobe Photoshop, Adobe Illustrator and Procreate

Artistic Technique :

Rhythmic dot patterns, Organic forms and Symbolic storytelling

Design Principles :

Movement, Harmony and Repetition

Medium :

Digital illustration crafted with layered textures and folk-inspired motifs

Art & Craft styles :

Bhil art

Curator :

Dr. Rikimi Madhukaillya

Conceptualiser & Artistic Director :

Akhil Vadehra

Craft Researchers :

Gautham, Hemanth, Nihad

Artists' Statement

The beauty of Gond, Saora, Sohrai and Khovar art moved my core, how they tell stories of life, growth and care through simple, earthy forms. While creating this piece, I felt the pulse of the earth, the rhythm of community and the quiet strength of togetherness. Each line and color carries warmth, balance and belonging. For me, this artwork is a prayer to harmony a reminder that when we build with love, we build not just homes, but life itself.

Curator's Statement

Dream Harbour unfolds like a river of hope and collective resilience. Drawing inspiration from the traditional Bhil art style of India, the work celebrates the interconnectedness of community, nature and shared growth. Through its intricate dots, vibrant colors and fluid forms, the composition evokes the gathering of people coming together to create lives and homes imbued with care and dignity. Each house depicted within the piece transcends mere shelter; it embodies safety, belonging and the aspiration for a better future. The river's movement illustrates the transformative work of Habitat for Humanity, connecting countless lives and guiding them toward stability, compassion and opportunity. The artwork articulates the values of unity, inclusion and sustainable living that define the organisation's mission. Interpreted through the lens of Bhil artistic traditions, the river becomes a metaphor for life itself, carrying dreams, stories and aspirations. Every dot represents a heartbeat, every hue a voice calling for connection. As the river flows across the canvas, communities emerge, homes take shape and hearts find solace. Dream Harbour is not merely a visual creation—it is a meditation on spirit and solidarity, where compassion flows ceaselessly, weaving lives together in dignity, love and the beauty of shared humanity.





Art of *Giving*



Our Partnership with Northern Trust

With the support of Northern Trust, Habitat for Humanity India has advanced community development initiatives across Karnataka, Assam and Maharashtra focusing on housing and provision of basic services such as building sanitation units and access to clean energy.

In Karnataka, Habitat strengthened sanitation infrastructure in government schools, creating safer and more hygienic learning environments for students. In Assam, disaster-affected families were provided with Emergency Shelter Kits, helping them rebuild their lives with dignity and stability.

In Maharashtra, families have built new homes in partnership with Habitat India. Each home was equipped with a solar lighting system bringing energy security to rural families. To further support local development, a sanitation unit was constructed at a nearby school, improving hygiene and strengthening educational infrastructure.

Through this enduring partnership, Habitat for Humanity India and Northern Trust continue to build brighter, more resilient futures empowering families and communities to thrive through safe homes, sustainable energy and improved sanitation.



Mr. Suresh Jethwani

India Chief Administrative Officer &
Pune Site Lead, Northern Trust

At Northern Trust, our enterprise vision is rooted in building a future where every individual has the opportunity to thrive. Our collaboration with Habitat for Humanity India exemplifies this commitment—by supporting housing, solar energy and sanitation initiatives in Khed, Pune, we've not only enhanced the living conditions of families in need but also empowered communities with dignity, health and hope. This collaboration is a testament to how strategic CSR can drive meaningful, lasting impact.



The house her sons promised

Prabhabei Sawant

Pune, Maharashtra

After losing both her sons, Prabhabei Sawant finds shelter and strength in a new home built by Habitat for Humanity India.

When Prabhabei Sawant walks along a narrow mud path in her village in Khed block of Pune district in Maharashtra, the morning rain has left puddles in the red earth and the air smells of wet soil.

A few steps later, the new house comes into view- the house her two sons always promised but never lived to build. It stands solid on a small rise of land, its walls of brick and cement painted pale blue. The roof is tiled and a slim solar panel fixed on a pole feeds the bulbs inside. Before this, the family huddled in a hut of tin sheets held down by stones for many years. “When it rained, water came through every hole,” Prabhabei says. “We pushed the pots and bags to one corner and waited for the storm to pass.”

But nothing had prepared them for what came next.

The younger son was the first to go, taken by the COVID wave. “We never saw his face at the end,” she says. One year later, the elder son died in a road accident while returning from a work site in another state. “He had gone only to earn a living,” Damu Sawant, her husband, says, his voice low. “He always said, ‘I will build you a strong house.’ That was his dream for us.”

The house has one kitchen, one hall, one bedroom and a separate bathroom and toilet. Sunlight falls through two small windows onto a smooth, tiled floor. Their daughter-in-law, Shobha Sawant, now lives here with her children. She leaves at dawn to wash clothes and utensils in nearby homes and comes back before dusk.

“It still hurts every day,” Shobha says. “But I feel some peace knowing Aai and Baba no longer worry about the roof breaking. He would have wanted that.” She looks around the hall. “I want to fill this place the way he planned. First a TV, then a sofa so they can sit comfortably.”

Their other daughter-in-law works in Mumbai along with her two children and visits every chance she gets. Meanwhile, Prabhabei and Damu still take farm jobs when neighbours call. “We are old,” he says, “but our hands still work and the fields still need workers.”

For their grandchildren, the biggest change is light and privacy. A bulb in the hall lets them finish their homework after sunset. A second bulb hangs in the bedroom, bright enough for evening prayers. The new toilet means no more trips to the bushes before dawn. “The children do not have to go outside in the dark,” Prabhabei says. “That makes me rest easy.”

She shows the kitchen, a neat space with a clay stove and two steel shelves. In the evening, as the sky turns grey, the solar bulb flicks on. The children open their books on the floor of the hall and the older couple sit nearby, watching.

Habitat for Humanity India built the house a few months after the elder son’s funeral. The group brought masons, bricks and hope in equal measure. “It was like our boys sent them,” Damu says. “Strangers came and did what our sons couldn’t.” Prabhabei says, standing in the doorway, “One day their children will grow up here. That thought keeps us moving.”



Our Partnership with Max Estates in Haryana

In the villages of Aakera and Bhudla located in Rewari district, Haryana, fifty marginalised families are transforming their lives through safe and stable housing. For years, these families lived in inadequate shelters that offered little protection from the weather or a sense of security.

To change this reality, Habitat for Humanity India, in partnership with Max Estates, launched a housing project to build 50 homes — implemented in two phases.

In the first phase, 25 families in Aakera received the keys to their new homes. Today, they have moved in and are building a better, brighter future for themselves and their children. The second phase of the project is currently underway in Bhudla village, where 25 more families will soon experience the joy of owning a safe, dignified home.

Through this collaboration, Habitat for Humanity India and Max Estates are working together to strengthen communities, empower families and create lasting change — one home at a time.



Sahil Vachani
Vice Chairman and MD
Max Estates Limited

It has been a truly meaningful collaboration with Habitat for Humanity to bring positive change to the underprivileged communities in parts of Haryana by building 50 new homes for them. This initiative reflects our core value of Sevabhav, the spirit of selfless service and we take great pride in helping build these homes that bring comfort and hope to many.

As we move into the next phase of our collaboration, we look forward to continuing this journey of bringing real wellbeing to the communities and enabling them to truly LiveWell.



A new dawn for Pooja

Pooja

Aakera village, Rewari District, Haryana

Pooja, a 28-year-old widow and mother of two, lived in a single, cramped room in Aakera village. With no access to a toilet or clean water, daily life was a constant struggle marked by fear, shame and exhaustion.

Each morning, before the village woke up, Pooja would step out in the dark to relieve herself in the open fields. “I always feared being seen. The risk of harassment was real and it made me anxious every single day,” she recalls softly. With no private space at home, she would bathe in a narrow alley between houses before sunrise, racing against time and judgement.

Inside their tiny, rented room, life was no easier. Her two sons, Arun (13) and Tarun (15), slept on the only bed while Pooja rested on the cold floor. “My back aches all the time,” she says. “And without a proper door, I constantly worry about our safety.” During heavy rains, water seeped through the roof and walls, forcing them to sleep under a tarpaulin. “The dampness made us all fall sick,” she adds.

Pooja is a street vendor and sells cosmetics from a small cart in the local market. She earns just enough to scrape by, with ₹2,500 going towards rent and ₹6,000 set aside for her sons’ education — a sacrifice she makes willingly. “I want them to have a better future. That’s all I hope for.”

Hope came in the form of Habitat for Humanity India. When she heard about the opportunity to build a new home, she filled the form with trembling hands, uncertain of what the future would hold. “When I got the call saying I was selected, it felt like a miracle,” she said, her eyes welling up.

On 19th November 2024, twenty-five families in Aakera village, Rewari, including Pooja’s, moved one step closer to stability and dignity as they received the keys to their new homes.

The impact was immediate. “For the first time, I have a place that feels safe. A proper toilet, a sturdy roof and space for my children to study,” she shares. No longer burdened by rent, she has opened a savings account for the future. “I feel secure, like I can finally start planning ahead.”

Her new home is simple, yet full of life. Curtains hang in the windows; flowerpots brighten the entrance and fairy lights dance on the walls. The space has brought freedom. Freedom to rest, to work, to dream. “I no longer have to rush through everything before dawn. I can finally breathe. I am truly grateful. This home has given me the strength to look forward to tomorrow,” she says.

For Pooja, this home is a new foundation. A safe place to raise her children. A symbol of dignity restored.



Our Partnership with HSBC and ReNew

Lighting Lives

Providing Rural Schools with Access to Renewable Energy
A programme by HSBC, ReNew and Habitat for Humanity India

Climate change has a far-reaching impact on human life, with children often being among the most vulnerable. The consequences of a changing climate threaten their health, education and protection. Recognising this, Habitat for Humanity India in partnership with ReNew and HSBC decided to implement a project called Lighting Lives to provide government schools with access to renewable energy.

The initiative was launched in November 2022 and is being implemented in a phase-wise manner. In the first two phases (2022-24) a total of 88 schools were equipped with solar energy and 83 schools were equipped with setting up of digital labs in Gujarat, Karnataka and Rajasthan. With the support of a partner organisation, Lighting Lives also raised awareness about climate change among students to nurture a new generation of young climate champions through a special educational curriculum called Young Climate Leadership Programme.

In phase three (2024-25) of the project, sustainable solar energy solutions have been established in 54 government schools across the states of Rajasthan and Maharashtra.

In FY 2026 (2025-26), the fourth phase of the intervention is underway in Rajasthan and Maharashtra.



Mr. Jitendra Routray
Head of CSR, ReNew

Working with Habitat for Humanity over the past three years has been an incredibly rewarding experience. As one of our most trusted and established partners, they have brought deep expertise, compassion and an impressive community reach to the Lighting Lives programme. Their dedication on the ground has been excellent - from implementation to creating impact. It has been a partnership built on trust and a shared purpose and we look forward to continuing this journey together.

We are deeply grateful for our long-standing partnership with HSBC, whose continued support has helped us build homes, respond to disasters and create lasting impact in communities across India.



Uninterrupted Power, Uninterrupted Teaching

Zilla Parishad Primary School Shindi village, Kaij block, Beed district, Maharashtra

Until recently, education at the Zilla Parishad Primary School in Shindi village, Kaij block of Beed district in Maharashtra, was dictated by one unpredictable factor: electricity. Frequent power outages forced teachers to plan lessons based on when lights and fans might work and digital classrooms often sat idle.

Today, the school tells a very different story — one of resilience, innovation and transformation. Thanks to solar electrification under the Lighting Lives initiative, the school now has a reliable, round-the-clock power supply, enabling uninterrupted teaching and learning for its students — all while promoting renewable energy and climate action.

Situated in a village of around 3,000 people, the school had already secured digital teaching aids. However, without a stable electricity supply, these tools remained largely unused.

“Despite having the resources, we were unable to use them effectively due to constant power cuts,” recalls Mr. Pramod Awaskar, the school’s Headmaster. “Electricity, along with food, water and shelter, is a basic need in today’s world.”

During the sweltering summers, students sat through entire days in stifling heat. Monsoons brought darkness into classrooms, disrupting focus and learning. Administrative work stalled. Even essential facilities, like the sanitary pad dispenser in the girls’ washroom, were inoperative without electricity.

The installation of solar panels has dramatically changed the landscape. “The school is more efficient with each passing day,” says Mr. Awaskar. “We can now use our digital resources fully and our school has become more vibrant and productive.”

For the students, the change is palpable. Kavya, a class 4 student, prefers staying back at school after classes to complete her homework. “Our homes still have power cuts. It is hard to study after sunset,” she says. “Here, I can sit under a fan, turn on the lights and even revise on the smart TV.”

The school has also seen a behavioural shift. “We are more disciplined now,” Kavya adds with a shy smile. “The CCTV cameras keep us on our toes — if anyone misbehaves, the teachers know!”

Class 6 student Shreyas shares how the extra learning hours have boosted his academic confidence. “Now we learn Science and Mathematics better. Teachers show us videos from YouTube to explain topics,” he says. “We understand more because we are not interrupted by power cuts.”

The benefits of solar power go beyond academics. Teacher Sunita Khorde highlights how it has transformed hygiene and operations. “The sanitary pad dispenser is finally functional. We are also able to update student portals and maintain school records on the computer during school hours,” she explains.

“Even managing groceries for the mid-day meal scheme, helping students apply for scholarships and maintaining teacher profiles — it is all done digitally now. The children are most excited about the smart TVs. They switch them on by themselves, start lessons and even the morning prayer without help,” she adds with pride.

When children choose to stay longer at school, it speaks volumes. It signifies that the school is no longer just a place of instruction, but a nurturing, resource-rich space where children feel safe, inspired and empowered.



Our Partnership with Rockwell Automation

Through its steadfast support, Rockwell Automation India Pvt. Ltd. has enabled Habitat for Humanity India to bring the power of renewable energy to underserved communities across Delhi NCR, Nagaland, West Bengal, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, Manipur and Assam. Together, we have provided 800 families from low-income and socially disadvantaged groups, including tribal communities in Maharashtra, access to clean, reliable lighting and enhancing the quality of life in rural homes. The collaboration was further strengthened through solar power installations in two government schools in Tamil Nadu and Maharashtra, ensuring sustainable electricity for improved learning environments.

In the most recent phase of our partnership, Rockwell Automation supported Habitat India's solar energy initiative to power 14 rural schools across Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu and Haryana. By ensuring uninterrupted electricity, the initiative enables the effective use of lighting, fans and digital tools, creating brighter and more engaging classrooms for students and teachers alike.

From an environmental standpoint, the solar systems are expected to generate nearly 75,000 kW of clean energy every year, significantly reducing the schools' carbon footprint while promoting sustainability.



Mr. Chitrabhanu Ghosh
Director and General Counsel AP
Rockwell Automation India Pvt. Ltd.

The impact of our solar lighting initiative goes far beyond illuminating classrooms. By providing reliable electricity, we are enabling the use of lighting, fans and digital tools — transforming schools into vibrant, functional spaces for students, teachers and the broader community. We are proud to collaborate with Habitat for Humanity India to bring clean energy access to the places that need it the most, empowering education and fostering opportunity.



Project NIRMANSHREE

Supported by the European Union

Project Nirmanshree Empowers Women in the Construction Sector

Habitat for Humanity India's Project Nirmanshree, funded by the European Union aimed to empower women by facilitating their entry into the traditionally male-dominated construction sector, which is the second-largest employment generator in India, offering them opportunities for better livelihood and making the housing eco-system conducive for women. 'Nirman', translated from Hindi means 'construction'. 'Shree', adapted from the ancient Sanskrit language represents the 'female gender'. In combining the two words, Nirmanshree means 'Building Women'.

This endeavour included empowering marginalised and low-income women through construction and entrepreneurship training, establishing or strengthening women-led social enterprises, facilitating access to government schemes, advocating for women's needs via policy briefs and assisting families in improving their habitats.

Project Locations

Maharashtra (Beed and Osmanabad) and Odisha (Jajpur and Dhenkanal).

Impact

3,275 women trained in technical and enterprise development skills.

3,007 women trained in construction skills through Recognition of Prior Learning (RPL).

2,956 women certified as Assistant Masons by the Government of India's National Skill Development Corporation.

50 women-led social enterprises established in Maharashtra and Odisha.

Orientation provided to *2,12,719* women on construction basics and government schemes.

These activities were accompanied by various visibility actions, such as street plays, wall paintings, Nirman-Haat exhibitions and awareness campaigns.



Mr. Laurent le Danois

Team Leader, Cooperation Section
Delegation of the European Union
to India and Bhutan

Project Nirmanshree stands as a testament to the European Union's commitment to fostering meaningful partnerships and advancing gender equality in India. Through our collaboration with Habitat for Humanity India, the project has empowered women at the grassroots to become skilled entrepreneurs in the low-cost and green housing sector. It has also created a replicable model that enhances the delivery of sustainable housing services through both government and private sector engagement. We deeply value Habitat's tireless efforts and innovative approach in uniting and empowering marginalised women, helping them gain confidence, independence and a renewed sense of dignity.



Pramila's Journey from Bricks to Dream Home

Pramila

Dhenkanal, Odisha

In the tranquil village of Barakoli, nestled amidst the lush green landscapes of Dhenkanal (Odisha), resides a woman whose resilience and determination have become the bedrock of her success story. Meet Pramila Malick, a beacon of hope and empowerment in her community.

For two decades, Pramila has called Barakoli her home. Yet, it was not until she embarked on a journey with Habitat for Humanity India's Project Nirmanshree that her life took a transformative turn. Initially confined within the walls of her home, Pramila's world expanded as she eagerly enrolled in the Recognition of Prior Learning – a training programme organised by Habitat India under Project Nirmanshree.

With each passing day of the training, Pramila's confidence soared. From mastering the art of bricklaying to understanding the nuances of construction materials, she absorbed knowledge like a sponge, eager to break free from the confines of her previous existence. It was during this time that she discovered her latent potential - the ability to construct her own home.

Armed with newfound skills and determination, Pramila embarked on a journey to build her dream home. Alongside her three daughters, she toiled tirelessly, mixing sand and cement, laying bricks and overseeing every aspect of construction including supervising and at times correcting the work done by local labourers. Her efforts bore fruit, as she and her daughters watched their humble abode take shape brick by brick.

But Pramila's journey didn't end there. Empowered by Project Nirmanshree, she ventured into the realm of entrepreneurship. Equipped with a sewing machine and training in tailoring, she began stitching clothes - petticoats, blouses and later masks during the pandemic - to sell to local shops. Their small enterprise flourished, providing a steady source of income for the family.

Today, Pramila's home stands as a testament to her indomitable spirit and unwavering determination. As she stitches clothes in the comfort of her humble abode, she dreams of a brighter future for her daughters. With the eldest aspiring to become a teacher, the middle one pursuing higher education and the youngest still in school, Pramila's aspirations know no bounds. Despite the challenges that lie ahead, she remains steadfast in her commitment to provide her daughters with the best opportunities life has to offer.

Reflecting on her journey, Pramila acknowledges the profound impact Project Nirmanshree has had on her life. "The training I got from Project Nirmanshree equipped me with skills, knowledge and strength. This experience enabled me to build a home of my own."

From a simple homemaker to a confident entrepreneur, she has defied the odds and emerged triumphant. And as she looks towards the horizon, she does so with hope, knowing that with determination and perseverance, anything is possible.



Our Partnership with **Kalyan Jewellers**

In 2017, Habitat for Humanity India partnered with Kalyan Jewellers to build homes for low income, marginalised families in Andhra Pradesh, Odisha and Telangana. Habitat India built 887 homes for underprivileged families under this partnership.



Mr. T. S. Kalyanaraman

Managing Director,
Kalyan Jewellers

We partnered with Habitat for Humanity India as part of the Government of India's "Housing for All" initiative, a chapter that remains memorable in our journey of giving back. Through this collaboration, we supported the construction of homes that offered families not just shelter, but stability, security and the promise of new beginnings. Each home we helped bring to life was a small yet meaningful step toward building stronger, more resilient communities.

This partnership, rooted in purpose, also served as a reminder of the real difference thoughtful action can make in people's lives. It stands as a noteworthy chapter in Kalyan Jewellers' journey of contributing to society, reflecting our belief in supporting initiatives that create tangible, lasting impact

Our Partnership with M. K. Tata Trust

Over the years, Habitat for Humanity India has partnered with M. K. Tata Trust to improve sanitation access for vulnerable families in Maharashtra. Through this collaboration, M. K. Tata Trust has supported in the construction of Individual Household Latrines (IHHLs) for low-income tribal and marginalised families since December 2020. More than 80 families have been supported through this initiative, helping them lead healthier and more dignified lives through improved hygiene and sanitation facilities.



Mrs. Piloo M. K. TATA
Chairperson and Managing Trustee,
THE M. K. TATA TRUST

Empowering women begins with creating spaces that uphold their dignity and safety. Through our collaboration with Habitat for Humanity India, we are working to strengthen housing and WASH initiatives that enable women and girls to live with confidence and security



Nirav Mehta

Director – www.YatraDham.Org

At YatraDham, our journey began with a simple yet profound purpose — to make every spiritual journey in India accessible, meaningful and memorable for every family. We have been blessed by the trust and love of thousands of pilgrims who travel seeking peace, purpose and connection.

Temples, in their essence, are spiritual homes — abodes of faith and wellness. Likewise, every home is an abode of wellbeing, where dignity, safety and belonging take root. In this belief, YatraDham's mission beautifully aligns with Habitat for Humanity India's vision — building homes, communities and hope for families across the nation. Our work in promoting wellness, harmony and responsible travel finds a shared heartbeat in Habitat's tireless commitment to human dignity.

As Habitat marks 42 years of transformative work and celebrates two decades of the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee, we salute the visionary leadership of Smt. Rajashree Birla, whose compassion and stewardship have been instrumental in shaping this enduring legacy of hope.

May this milestone and the Impact Gala 2025 remind us that building a home is not merely an act of construction — it is an act of creation. It is where faith finds form and families find peace; where walls shelter not just lives, but dreams. Every home is a temple of wellbeing and every brick laid with love reflects the inner home we build with faith. Together, let us continue to build foundations of safety, dignity and hope — one home, one family and one community at a time.

Gaurav Bhandari

CEO, Monarch Network Capital

At Monarch Network Capital, we envision a future where financial empowerment fosters stronger communities and brighter lives. Our commitment extends beyond numbers to creating lasting value through innovation, trust and building connections that enable individuals and institutions to thrive in an ever-evolving market.

True prosperity is grounded in stability and opportunity, reflecting Habitat for Humanity India's dedication to empowering families at the bottom of the pyramid through decent shelter. By joining hands with Habitat, we reaffirm our belief in investing in both the human spirit and social progress.

This partnership embodies our shared aspiration to build a foundation for sustainable growth and hope. As Habitat celebrates their impact and significant milestones, we join in honouring this journey of collaboration and compassion. We are confident that together we can inspire meaningful change to uplift lives and communities across India.





Celebrity *Voices*



Transforming lives and communities



A home is more than four walls. It is laughter in a room, learning in light, healing when the world seems fragile. It is where health, opportunity and belonging take root. That is the work Habitat does with hearts, hands and relentless determination

Mr. John Abraham

Actor, National Award-Winning Producer and Brand Ambassador, Habitat for Humanity India

My association with Habitat for Humanity India began over two and a half decades ago and it has been a privilege to witness the organisation's unwavering commitment to building homes, hope and dignity for families across the country. From the Carter Work Project in Lonavala in 2006 to leading John's Brigade and engaging young changemakers through the Rupee for Change campaign, I have seen firsthand how Habitat's work transforms lives and strengthens communities.

As Habitat for Humanity India marks 42 years of impact and celebrates 20 years of the IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee, it is a moment to reflect on how far we have come and to reaffirm our shared commitment to ensuring that every family has a decent place to live.

A home is more than four walls. It is laughter in a room, learning in light, healing when the world seems fragile. It is where health, opportunity and belonging take root. That is the work Habitat does with hearts, hands and relentless determination.

I am more committed than ever to this journey. I believe that every home we build, every roof we raise, every family we uplift, brings us one step closer to the world we dream of one where every person knows the security of home, the promise of tomorrow and the courage to hope.

Habitat's mission aligns closely with the Honourable Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi's vision of Housing for All and the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana.

I commend Mrs. Rajashree Birla, Chair of Habitat India's IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee and Mrs. Sheila Kripalani, Chair of the Board of Trustees and Mr. Anand K. Bolimera, National Director, Habitat for Humanity India for their visionary leadership in advancing Habitat's mission of building homes, communities and hope.

I urge everyone to come forward and support Habitat for Humanity India. Together, we can build a future where every family lives dignity in a home of their own.



A humbling journey

Mr. Ashish Nangia

Habitat Volunteer

I have had the privilege of being part of Habitat for Humanity India's inspiring work since 2005. Over the years, I have joined volunteer builds, worked alongside families to construct their homes and supported Habitat's efforts in different parts of the world. Each experience has been deeply humbling — a reminder that when people come together with compassion and purpose, real change happens.

What makes Habitat truly special is its spirit of participation. The idea of volunteers building homes with their own hands is not just about constructing walls and roofs — it's about building dignity, confidence and hope. Every home completed represents a family's dream realised and a community strengthened.

I am proud to be a Habitat volunteer and champion, standing with the organisation in its vision to create a world where everyone has a decent place to live.



The idea of volunteers building homes with their own hands is not just about constructing walls and roofs — it's about building dignity, confidence and hope.



Walking the path towards housing for all

Mr. R. Madhavan

Actor and National Award-Winning Filmmaker

My journey with Habitat for Humanity India has been profoundly moving. From supporting initiatives in India and the UK to being part of the Jimmy and Rosalynn Carter Work Project, I have seen how a safe, dignified home can do. It protects families, gives people hope, a foundation and an opportunity to dream.

As we celebrate over four decades of Habitat India's work, I am humbled by the countless lives touched and communities uplifted. Every family deserves not just a house, but a home that nurtures dignity and opportunity.

I believe strongly in Habitat's vision of building a world where everyone has a decent place to live. This vision echoes our Honourable Prime Minister Shri. Narendra Modi's clarion call of Housing for All and the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana.

What leaves the deepest mark on me is this: every home built breathes life into someone's dream — children learning, health restored, ambitions kindled. I feel honoured to be a part of this journey. Looking ahead, I commit myself to walk this path with even greater intent so that together, we may ensure that every family finds the place they can truly call home.



Every family deserves not just a house, but a home that nurtures dignity and opportunity.



Overcoming the wrath of disasters

Ms. Jacqueline Fernandez

Actress

It gives me immense happiness to be back with Habitat for Humanity India, an organisation that has always inspired me with its vision of building homes, communities and hope. I have walked shoulder to shoulder with Habitat for Humanity India in times of disaster from leading crowdfunding efforts to rebuild homes in flood-affected Kerala to mobilising awareness through social media.

As we celebrate this special milestone of completing 42 years of building a place where everyone has a decent place to live, I am reminded that every home built offers more than shelter; it is a testament to hope, solidarity and human dignity. I look forward to continuing this journey and even when challenges loom, together we can build.



Every home built offers more than shelter; it is a testament to hope, solidarity and human dignity.



My journey of building dignity

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Watching those homes rise from the rubble and then seeing the sheer joy and relief on people's faces when we handed over the keys was pure magic.

Ms. Pooja Bedi

Actor | Founder – Happy Soul

My journey with Habitat for Humanity India has been nothing short of soul-stirring. When I first joined hands with them, it wasn't just about building homes, it was about building hope, dignity and a future brick by brick. The alignment was instant. Habitat's mission resonated deeply with my own belief that true wellness begins with a sense of security, belonging and a roof that shelters both dreams and laughter.

One of my most memorable experiences was championing the Mahad flood relief and reconstruction project. I still remember racing against time, calling friends, Rotary Clubs and supporters, pooling every ounce of goodwill and resource possible to help families who'd lost everything. Watching those homes rise from the rubble and then seeing the sheer joy and relief on people's faces when we handed over the keys was pure magic. That moment reminded me that compassion, when put into action, can literally rebuild lives.

And oh, the Carter Work Projects in Lonavala and Thailand! What a humbling, heart-expanding adventure. There I was, hammer in hand, sweat on brow, working alongside volunteers, locals and legends, realising that love and humanity truly have no borders. Every wall we built wasn't just concrete and mortar; it was a collective prayer for a better world.

Over the years, I've had the joy of amplifying Habitat's mission through media, events and conversations, anywhere and everywhere I could! Because let's face it: everyone deserves the peace and pride of calling a place home.

What makes me happiest, though, is that my children, Alaya and Omar, have walked this path with me. They've seen firsthand that giving is the highest form of living. Together, we've shared the beauty of service, laughter and purpose which are lessons no classroom could ever teach.

Being associated with Habitat for Humanity has been one of the most fulfilling and grounding experiences of my life. It has reinforced my faith that when compassion meets action, miracles truly happen.





Habitat Charity Golf *Legacy*



Golf for Humanity

Habitat Charity Golf Tournament

In 2018, Habitat for Humanity teamed up with the Asian Tour, sanctioning body for Golf in Asia as the Sustainable Development Partner, bringing the need for decent housing closer to the hearts of the golfing community across Asia and the world.

As part of this partnership, the Asian Tour's season-long "Order of Merit" rankings were renamed the "Habitat for Humanity Standings." This branded leaderboard created massive visibility for Habitat across multiple broadcast channels in more than 14 countries in Asia, the Pacific and beyond.

The one-year partnership opened many doors. Several professional golfers became Habitat ambassadors, proudly wearing the Habitat logo on their golf apparel and bags during Asian Tour tournaments. Numerous activation events were organised both on and off the course in India, Indonesia, Malaysia, New Zealand, South Korea and Thailand.

Following this, Habitat for Humanity India launched its first-ever Charity Golf Tournament 2019 on 6th January 2019 under the leadership of Mr. Rajeev Menon, Strategic Advisor, Habitat for Humanity India. Since then Habitat India has organised six charity golf tournaments annually which have helped improved living conditions of over 300 households through housing, disaster response and access to basic services such as sanitation and water.

Through Habitat Charity Golf, many prominent industry and business leaders of India have become champions of Habitat and are helping us advance the cause of decent shelter.





Dr. Ramakrishnan Ramamurthi

Former Vice Chairman, JMD & CEO

Polycab Group

Chairman, Transformia Advisors

Over the years, I have had the privilege of witnessing and being part of Habitat for Humanity India's remarkable journey of building homes, communities and hope. Their mission to ensure that every family has a safe, affordable and dignified place to live resonates deeply with me. I have supported their numerous Fund raisers over the last decade or so.

My association with Habitat India began with their Pro-Am and Charity events. Later the Habitat for Heroes programme became especially close to my heart. Contributing towards building homes for the families of our fallen soldiers from Maharashtra was a profoundly moving experience. Seeing the house built and the key handover ceremony to the bereaved family members was so impactful and purposeful. This initiative not only brought comfort and dignity to those who have served our nation but also inspired many of my peers to come forward in support. It reaffirmed my belief that true impact happens when compassion evolves into collective action and that is the spirit that Habitat India embodies. For their dependents it means security, safety, a better education and a better health. Overall, a far better quality of life.

Since 2018, I have also had the pleasure of participating in the Habitat for Humanity India's Annual Charity Golf Tournaments — a meaningful platform that unites sport and purpose.

As Habitat for Humanity India celebrates over four decades of impact, I am reminded of a simple truth: Many of us are fortunate to have a home, some even more than one. But the real privilege lies in extending that gift to others. Every home built is more than a brick and mortar. It is an act of faith, a foundation for stability and a step towards a World where Everyone has a Decent Place to Live and a meaningful quality of life!



Gopal Ramakrishnan

Managing Director

Goodrich Maritime

In the aftermath of the Kerala floods, we supported Habitat for Humanity India in building homes for families affected by the natural disaster. It fills us with pride to see these families now living in safe, dignified homes — a place they can truly call their own. Habitat India is doing extraordinary work, transforming lives and communities with compassion and dedication.

I have also had the opportunity to witness Habitat's impact firsthand through the Habitat Charity Golf Tournament. The event beautifully blends the spirit of sport with the joy of giving, bringing together people who share a common goal: creating a world where every family has access to a decent home.

Supporting Habitat for Humanity India is more than philanthropy. It is a chance to be part of something that restores hope, builds resilience and strengthens communities. I am honoured to contribute to this journey and look forward to seeing more families empowered through safe and stable housing.



Arjun Nohwar

Senior Vice President and Managing Director,
India and South Asia, Warner Bros. Discovery

At Warner Bros. Discovery, we believe in the power of purposeful partnerships that create lasting change. Our association with Habitat for Humanity India reflects this belief - from supporting housing for families living in poor conditions to enabling access to renewable energy for households and schools across rural Maharashtra. Together, we are improving living conditions of the families and building pathways to a more sustainable future.

It is through such collaborations that we find meaningful ways to combine passion with purpose. The Habitat Charity Golf Tournament is a truly meaningful initiative where sport meets social impact. It's remarkable how this platform brings people together to engage and contribute to something greater than themselves.

What sets Habitat apart is their holistic approach. They don't just construct homes, they help build thriving communities rooted in dignity, stability and hope. We at Warner Bros. Discovery are proud to support this vision and remain committed to helping families move closer to a world where everyone has a decent place to live.



Shiv Kapur

Four-time Asian Tour-winning golfer and 2002 Arjuna Awardee

Golf is a wonderful medium to raise awareness for a cause as important as safe and decent housing. I have witnessed the work of Habitat for Humanity India up close over the years and have had the privilege of joining some of their Volunteer Builds. As a professional golfer, it gives me immense happiness to be able to give back and lend my support. It is inspiring to see how sport can unite people for a purpose and create meaningful change. I look forward to continuing my association with Habitat India and supporting their efforts to build homes, communities and hope.



Brian Lara

Former International Cricketer

The charity golf tournament organized by Habitat for Humanity India is an excellent initiative to help families in need of decent shelter and sanitation achieve strength, stability and self-reliance they need to build a better future for themselves.



Jeev Milkha Singh

International Golfer

I think it's one of the best things that Habitat for Humanity is doing. Building homes, giving somebody a shelter is a way to tell them that you can go out there and face the world.



Ajit Agarkar

Former Cricketer, Chair - BCCI Selection Committee

We need to do more tournaments like these and raise more awareness. This will support people who need it the most especially women. Home is the basic need of any individual. Hopefully there will be a day when every single person in India has a roof over their head.



Rashid Khan

Professional Golfer

It is really important to have your own house. Where I used to live, it was like a slum area. I started playing golf and I would get INR 10 to go to the golf course. With that amount, my father had to pay the rent and take care of the family. It was really tough. Hats off to what Habitat is doing!





Interwoven Sanctuaries

Digital Artist :

Samiksha Somani

Softwares Used :

Adobe Photoshop, Adobe Illustrator and Procreate

Artistic Technique :

Mixed-media composition inspired by mandala structure and indigenous dot painting.

Design Principles :

Unity and balance, Emphasising connection, Rhythm and Repetition

Medium :

Digital illustration with textural overlays of brick, geometric motifs and organic forms

Art & Craft styles :

Traditional Mandala Art, Indian Folk Art influences, Indigenous dot painting, Contemporary geometric design, Mixed media

Curator :

Dr. Rikimi Madhukaillya

Conceptualiser & Artistic Director :

Akhil Vadehra

Craft Researchers :

Gautham, Hemanth, Nihad

Artists' Statement

Interwoven Sanctuary emerged from a desire to translate hope and care into form. The mandala became a framework to express how lives, efforts and dreams intertwine in harmony. Each brick, line and droplet carries emotion—strength, empathy and shared purpose. The work is a visual meditation on unity, a celebration of collective action and a quiet invocation for dignity, belonging and human connection.)

Curator's Statement

Interwoven Sanctuary explores the profound connections that underpin the idea of home. Drawing from Indian folk and mandala traditions, the work embodies resilience, unity and collective care—the core values of Habitat for Humanity. Every element carries meaning: bricks evoke shelter, constellation-like links symbolize partnership and the water droplet signifies access to life's essentials. The circular form reflects the cyclical, interconnected nature of community. By blending traditional and contemporary forms, the piece celebrates collaboration, inclusion and the belief that safe, dignified homes are a shared human right.



Celebrating 42 Years *of* Building Homes *in* India

Key Milestones

1983

Habitat for Humanity's work begins in Khammam, erstwhile Andhra Pradesh, now Telangana. First Habitat homes were constructed in partnership with the families of Fatima Bibi and Gunde Venkulu.

1985 to 1995

Expansion of Habitat India's work from 1 affiliate in Khammam to 17 affiliates and 5 branches in 8 states across India.

1997

Global Village Volunteer Department established.

1999

Habitat responds to Super Cyclone in Odisha.

73 homes built for families affected by the cyclone.

2001

Earthquake in Gujarat. Habitat responds to the disaster and goes on to build 600 homes.

2003

Inauguration of the homes built in Renukoot at the hands of Mrs. Rajashree Birla.

A total of 110 homes built.

2004

Tsunami hits the East Coast of Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Pondicherry and Kerala on 26th December. Habitat India launches its disaster response initiative. Goes on to help 13,000 affected families in the wake of the tsunami in Tamil Nadu.

Offices established in Delhi, Mumbai and Chennai with Delhi as the National Office.

1984

First team of international volunteers arrive from the USA to build homes in India.

1996

Habitat Khammam, the first affiliate, dedicates its 1000th house on its 12th anniversary.

1998

Habitat for Humanity South Asian Regional Office (SARO) established in Delhi.

2000

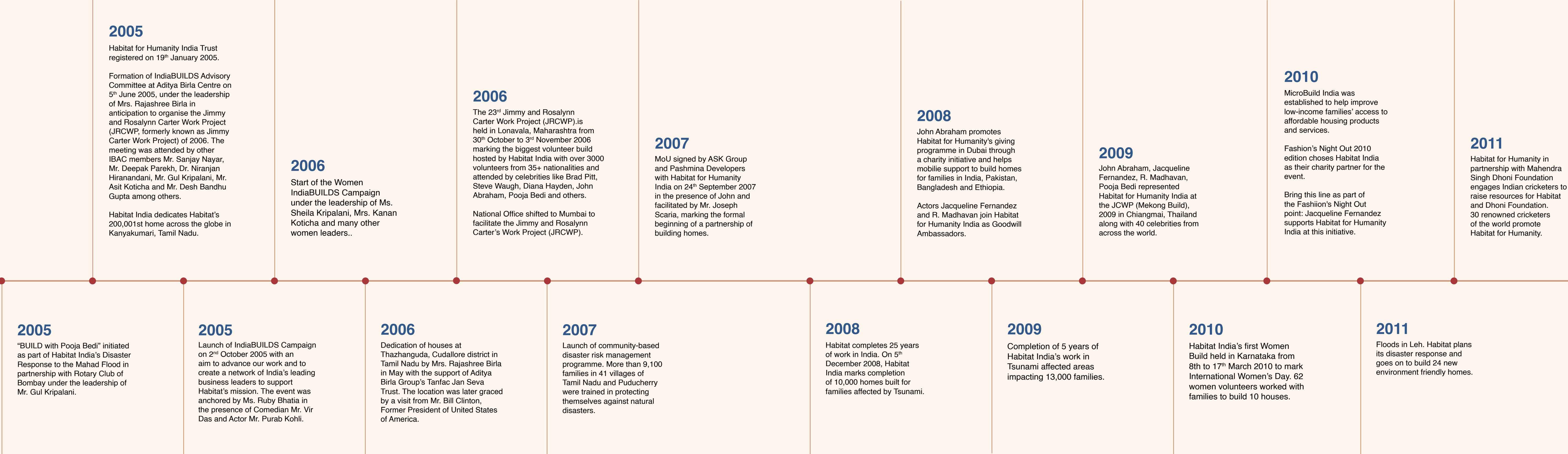
Habitat India's 5000th house dedicated in Tamil Nadu by Habitat for Humanity International's founder late Millard Fuller.

2002

The first-ever housing project supported by a corporate partner, HINDALCO of Aditya Birla Group started in Renukoot, Uttar Pradesh.

2004

Popular Indian film-star John Abraham joins hands with Habitat for Humanity India through a campaign titled "Join John's Brigade".



2012

Habitat for Humanity India marks the start of its WASH (water, sanitation and hygiene) initiative and partners with a total of 2030 underprivileged families across India to help them build household sanitation units.

2014

Habitat India initiates the construction of 83 new houses and one community hall for its response to Cyclone Hudhud in Andhra Pradesh.

2016

Actor Jacqueline Fernandez launches the ‘Jacqueline Builds’ campaign in partnership with Habitat India to rebuild the lives of families affected by the floods in Tamil Nadu. Leads a volunteer build in Chennai, Tamil Nadu on 9th April 2016.

2018

Habitat India holds the first edition of its Legacy Build in Karjat.

2018

Habitat for Humanity becomes the sustainable development partner of the Asian Tour; sanctioning body for Golf in Asia and one among the Professional Golf Association (PGA) bodies in the world led by the then Chairman of Asian Tour - Mr. Jimmy Masrin. Thanks to Jimmy’s leadership, Habitat India today has a professional golfing property known as Habitat India Charity Golf Tournament held annually for the last 6 years under the leadership of Rajeev Menon.

2017

John Abraham promotes Habitat India’s ‘Rupee for Change’ campaign with an aim to engage youth for the cause of housing.

2015

Habitat forms the Sensitise to Sanitise coalition with an objective to contribute to the nation-wide campaign of Swachh Bharat Abhiyan launched by Honourable Prime Minister Shri. Narendra Modi.

2013

Natural disaster in Uttarakhand. Habitat India distributes 582 emergency shelter kits and builds 225 transitional homes, 127 permanent houses and repairs 50 homes for the affected families.

Jammu and Kashmir floods: Habitat India builds 106 new houses and distributes 1,028 emergency shelter kits.

2019

A charity gala is held to commemorate 35 years of Habitat for Humanity in India and 15 years of IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee chaired by Mrs. Rajashree Birla.

2020

Habitat India initiates a humanitarian response to COVID-19. A total of 17,60,453 people are served through Habitat’s Road to Recovery: COVID-19 Response.

2021

Rebuild Kerala Programme concludes after supporting 1,76,052 families in response to the 2018 Kerala Floods. Actor Jacqueline Fernandez leads the second edition of Jacqueline Builds to support the initiative. Actor Shweta Menon joins her.

2022

‘Lighting Lives’ — one of Habitat for Humanity India’s largest initiatives focused on providing renewable energy to rural schools launched in partnership with HSBC and ReNew.

2023

Completion of Habitat for Humanity India’s Project Nirmanshree; a women empowerment programme, funded by the European Union.

Patrick Canagasingham, COO, Habitat for Humanity International visits Habitat India with an aim to strengthen our mission in India.

2024

Legacy Build 2.0 – More than 20 volunteers from Habitat for Humanity Japan’s campus chapters partner with homeowners in Nashik (Maharashtra) from 3rd March 2024 to 8th March 2024 under the leadership of Anthony Miller, Partner and CEO, American Manufacturing Renewal LLC and APDC leader and Cecilia Melin, Executive Director, Habitat Japan and Managing Partner, Asian Technology Advisors Y.K.

Mr. Jonathan Reckford, Chief Executive Officer of Habitat for Humanity International, visits India on 21st August 2024. Hands over the climate resilient housing project supported by India’s golfing fraternity.

Meetings with Habitat India’s Board of Trustees, IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee and community interactions are organised.

2025

Habitat India celebrates the legacy of 42 years of service and impact in India.

IndiaBUILDS Advisory Committee completes 20 years since its formation under the leadership of Mrs. Rajashree Birla.

2025

Legacy Build 3.0 led by Anthony Miller and Cecilia Melin is conducted in Bengaluru (Karnataka) in support of housing for the Hakki Pikki community.

Three Habitat homes in Odisha are awarded with IGBC NEST GOLD certification for climate resilient housing.





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Acknowledgments

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We extend our heartfelt appreciation to you for your guidance, encouragement and unwavering support. Your contributions continue to inspire and strengthen our collective efforts.



Mr. Ashish Nangia



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Ms. Rekha Joby

EDITOR
Krithika N
Akanksha Bansal
Ritwik Sawant

DESIGNER
Samiksha Somani

COVER ARTWORK
Meenakshi Setia

ARTWORKS BY
Samiksha Somani and Meenakshi Setia

CONCEPTUALISER & ARTISTIC DIRECTOR
Akhil Vadehra

CURATOR:
Dr. Rikimi Madhukaillya

CRAFT RESEARCH
Goutham Suresh
Nihad P. V.
S. N. Hemanth

LEGAL TEAM
Samad Ali
Pradeep Ratnam
Reena Jalan
Kochhar & Co.

CONTRIBUTORS
Aastha Chavan
Anand Kumar Bolimera
Anna Charly Jeyaraj
Annett Janet Furtado
Anthony Thomas
Derrick Fernandes
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Julia Ferraz

Kshirodinee P Sahu
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PHOTOGRAPHY:
Abhineet Dang
Arijit Sen
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Joseph Arokia Doss
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Note: This book is a project of Habitat for Humanity India. All content and images have been included in this book to the best of our information.

HABITAT FOR HUMANITY INDIA OFFICES

NATIONAL OFFICE

3rd Floor, AFL House, Lok Bharti Complex, Marol Maroshi Road,
Andheri (East), Mumbai - 400059, Maharashtra
Tel: +91 22 67846836

REGISTERED OFFICE

CNI Bhavan, Room No. 406,
4th Floor, 16 Pandit Pant Marg,
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Property No. 44, First floor, Block - G, Sector 3,
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No. 4DC-203, 3rd Block, 4th D Cross,
2nd Main, HRBR Layout, Kalyan Nagar,
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info@habitatindia.org

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